THE UNWRITTEN ONES

The Complete First Season

A LORESPINNER ORIGINAL

EPISODE ONE

One Night Only

♦

It started in the dark, the way the worst of it always would, with a child singing.

A small voice, off-key, a song that had lost most of itself somewhere along the way and kept going anyway. *Names are knots. Names are thread. Pull too hard — you disappear.* The kind of tune a kid learns without being taught, that comes from nowhere and stays for good.

Then light.

Strung bulbs, swaying warm over a striped archway, and above them, spelled out in glass and filament: GIDEON'S CARNIVAL OF ENDINGS & WONDERS. A calliope playing something that was almost the right song. Wagons painted the color of brand-new circus dreams, years from fading. And over the gate, patient in the bulbs, the promise that the whole thing turned on: ONE NIGHT ONLY.

Under the arch stood a man in a showman's coat.

Gideon Marr wore his sixty-odd years the way he wore the coat — like both had fit him twenty pounds ago. Bone-thin now, the fabric hanging off his shoulders in soft apology. But the eyes were quick and the eyes were warm, and if you didn't look too long you'd never catch the part of him that was sorry about something.

In front of him: a girl. Fifteen, maybe. Backpack over one shoulder, a library book tucked under her arm with the corners gone soft from too much rereading. She was counting out dollar bills, damp from her hand, and she was doing it carefully, the way you count when the count matters.

"You like stories, don't you," Gideon said.

She nodded. Hesitant first. Then not.

"This one's about a girl who got to be anything she wanted." Warm as a porch light, that voice. He tore her ticket himself and pressed it into her palm like a secret.

She went in — under the arch, into the light and the sugar-smell and the music that was almost right. She glanced back once, delighted, the way you look back at the person who gave you the thing. And the bright took her.

Gideon waved. She waved back. And then she was gone into it, and the smile stayed up on his face on its own, the way a light stays on in a room nobody's in anymore.

He covered a cough with his hat. Fit it back on his head without breaking stride, because salesmen don't cough.

Behind him the ticket booth opened, and a worker stepped out — nineteen at the most, face painted over in silver stars, eyes a hundred years too old for the

face they were parked in. The worker looked at Gideon. Gideon looked back. Neither of them said a word, but there was a whole argument in the nothing between them, and it was clear from the set of both their mouths that they'd each had it before and each already lost.

Gideon tipped his hat. Then he walked off into his carnival, whistling the gate tune a half-step truer than the calliope could manage.

Somewhere, low and close, something creaked. Like a book, opening its spine.

♦

Across an ocean and a whole ordinary world away, Leo London sat up in bed before he was awake.

One hand had already clamped down over his own wrist, hard, like something had bitten him there. Nothing had. There was never anything there. There was just the reflex, night after night, his body reaching to hold a wound it couldn't find.

He breathed. He counted the breaths, because counting was supposed to help. Counting got him to four. Four was where it always came apart.

The moon came through cheap blinds and laid the room out in pale strips — the posters peeling at one corner each, the sketchbooks stacked into a low barricade around a jar of broken pencils. Thirteen years old and already keeping walls between himself and the dark.

On the nightstand sat a feather on a leather cord. Gray-white, edged in black, too big for any bird this town had ever grown. Beside it lay a picture, half-drawn: three figures holding hands under a sky nobody had finished. And a fourth figure, scratched out — erased so hard the paper had torn.

Leo picked up the feather. He didn't put it on. He just held it, his thumb finding the groove worn smooth into the spine of it from a hundred nights of exactly this.

Down the hall the fridge shuddered, caught itself, settled into its hum.

"I'm awake," Leo said, under his breath. He said it like a password. Like something might be listening for it, and might need to be told.

He lay back down. Pulled the blanket to his chin. His eyes stayed open.

They stayed open a long time.

♦

Morning came to the kitchen the way it came to everything in that house — reluctantly, and without much to show for it.

Faded floral wallpaper. A fridge armored in magnets and old school drawings nobody had taken down in two years. A calendar still flipped to the wrong month, as if turning the page were a thing this family had run out of the strength to do.

Carter London worked the stove with his sleeves shoved up past the elbow, burning eggs that nobody had asked for. Eighteen and lean, hoodie half-zipped,

hair still wet from a shower that couldn't have lasted thirty seconds. He cooked like it was a fight and he was losing it on points.

Ava leaned in the doorway and watched him lose. Seventeen, dyed-black hair grown out of whatever cut it used to be, headphones ringing a beat around her neck for an audience of nobody. A sketchbook under one arm. Watching her brother ruin breakfast was, apparently, the morning's entertainment.

Leo slid into his chair and vanished down into his hoodie, the skin under his eyes bruised dark from another night of not-sleeping.

"You look like hell," Carter said.

"Didn't sleep."

Ava didn't even look up. "That makes what, four days."

Leo shrugged. Carter scraped eggs onto three plates and slid one across the table without looking, and for a while the silence did most of the eating.

Then Leo said, "Something's coming."

"Don't start."

"I'm not starting anything."

"You sound like Mom."

It landed wrong and everybody heard it land. Ava stopped chewing.

"She said it too," Ava said. "Before the crash."

"I know what she said."

"You don't believe her."

"No." Carter set the pan down harder than the pan deserved. "I don't. Because she left us."

"That's not fair."

"None of this is fair. And yet." He gestured at the table, the plates, the whole gray morning of it. "We still have to eat."

Leo pushed his plate away. Gently, like an apology. "I'm not hungry."

And that got Carter to finally look at him — really look, over the ruined eggs. "When's the last time you were?"

There wasn't an answer to that, so nobody gave one. Ava poured a glass of milk and carried it down the hall, and Leo peeled up out of his chair and followed her out, and Carter was left standing there holding a spatula and three breakfasts that nobody in this house was going to eat.

His jaw worked. Whatever was climbing up his throat, he swallowed it whole. Down the hall the fridge clanked and took up its hum again, strained now, uneven, like it too was tired of holding this place together.

♦

Ava's room was a sky of its own — sketches thumbtacked into constellations across the peeling wallpaper, books in leaning stacks, a cracked mug of tea gone cold enough to qualify as an heirloom.

She sat cross-legged on the bed with the sketchbook on one knee, one foot bouncing to a beat only she could hear. Her phone lay face-down on its own glow beside her, and stacked up under the glass where she wouldn't look: *U ok?*

— *Call me? — Ava come out. just for a bit.* Face-down was her whole answer to all of them.

She drew. Erased. Drew again, faster, until the pencil snapped clean in her fingers.

She didn't flinch. She just breathed, and reached into a drawer full of tangled earbuds and dried-out pens for another one — and her hand stopped.

She drew out a folded flyer instead. Bold type across the top: COLLEGE PORTFOLIO PREP — SUMMER INTENSIVE.

She held it the way you hold a photo of somebody you used to be. She read it one more time, the whole thing, top to bottom.

Then she tore it in half. And in half again. Confetti of the girl she'd been snowing quietly down into the trash.

She went back to the bed and back to the sketchbook, where three figures held hands: a boy with a feather, a girl with a crown of branches, a third who was half-shadow and half-fire.

Behind them, careful, she added a door.

And then she locked it.

♦

In the living room Carter knelt at the old side table and took a slow breath before he opened it, the way a man breathes before lifting something heavy.

The drawer was a museum of arrears. Unopened envelopes. FINAL NOTICE printed in a cheerful red that had clearly never met the people it was threatening. And taped to the lamp, in their mother's handwriting, a sign: DO NOT THROW OUT — guarding, with her whole authority, a lamp worth about eight dollars.

He pulled the key from the cord around his neck. Lifted a battered metal lockbox out of the drawer and sat down on the rug with it, cross-legged, a kid about to do again the exact thing he'd sworn to himself he was done doing.

Inside: eighteen dollars and fifty-seven cents, in wrinkled bills and pennies gone warm from the box. Two wedding rings, worn smooth. A photo of the whole family at a fair, all of them, smiling like people who don't know yet.

And a ticket stub, faded soft: *GIDEON'S CARNIVAL OF ENDINGS & WONDERS.*

He turned it over. He'd turned it over a hundred times. On the back, in their mother's looping hand, the ink gone the rust color that old ink goes:

If it comes back before I do —

And then nothing. The sentence just walked off the edge of the paper and didn't come back.

He ran his thumb over the torn edge of it, careful, like the paper might wake up if he wasn't. Upstairs, footsteps. He closed the box quick, locked it, slid it home — practiced, all of it, a routine he'd worn smooth same as Leo and the feather.

But the stub didn't go back in the box. The stub went into the chest pocket of his jacket, over the heart, where it had been living lately.

♦

The knock came at the front door like a debt collector in a good mood. Three raps, cheerful.

Leo got there first and opened the door on nobody at all. Winter light. An empty street.

He found it tacked to the porch rail, damp along one edge: a poster. Elegant script curling over a drawing of a striped tent.

GIDEON'S CARNIVAL OF ENDINGS & WONDERS — ONE NIGHT ONLY.

And beneath that, smaller, and somehow more patient: RETURN WHAT WAS FORGOTTEN. REMEMBER WHAT WAS TAKEN.

He carried it inside flat on both palms, like water he didn't want to spill, and laid it on the hall table. And the ink moved. Barely. Breathing, almost — a slow rise and fall across the paper, like it knew it was being looked at and was deciding how much to let him see.

Under his shirt, against his chest, the feather woke up. A tingle, low and electric.

Leo went very still. He dug the half-drawn picture out of his hoodie pocket and unfolded it on the table beside the poster.

The symbol on the tent flap. The symbol in his own unfinished sky. The same hand had drawn both, and the hand was his.

"Who was it?" Ava, coming down the stairs.

He folded the picture away fast. "Wrong house."

First lie of the day. It wouldn't be the last.

♦

The wagons came in on a whistle — thin, off-key, the kind of sound a town half-remembers from a dream it had once and never told anybody about.

They rolled up the far end of Main Street, creaking and swaying, the paint the color of old circus dreams now, wheels tall as doors. Carnival workers walked alongside in vintage vests, faces painted bright, eyes not painted anything at all. Down the block, doors opened. Locals drifted out onto their porches. Kids materialized from nowhere the way kids do, pointing, cheering, and parents lifted their phones to catch it.

A little girl tugged her mother's sleeve.

"Mommy, it never left. It just forgot to show up last year."

The mother laughed. And then she didn't. She looked down at her daughter, and then out at the wagons rolling in, and she went hunting through herself for a single memory of them — and found no memory of them at all.

"...Right," she said, soft.

♦

Night, and the kitchen again, and dinner cooling untouched on three more plates.

Carter stood over the poster like it was evidence in a case he already knew he was going to lose. Ava read it upside down from her chair. Leo waited with his chin up, already braced for it.

"No," Carter said.

"It says one night —"

"I heard you. No."

"Solid parenting," Ava said, dry as chalk. "Airtight. No notes."

"Don't." That to Ava. Then, to Leo: "And do what, huh? Bike across town, at night, to a carnival that staples invitations to our porch?"

"Why not?"

"Because —" And there Carter stopped. There was a reason sitting right in his mouth, and everyone in the room could see him trade it for a smaller one before it could get out. "Because it's a scam with a Ferris wheel. That's all it is."

"That's not what you were going to say."

Silence. Ava's eyes moved between her brothers, tracking the thing that had just pulled taut in the air between them.

"Mom talked about it," Leo said. "Didn't she. Before."

"Go to bed, Leo."

"I'm thirteen, not —"

"*Go to bed.*"

Too loud. Even Carter flinched at the size of it. Leo stood up, slow about it, and walked past his brother without another word.

And on the way out, at the hallway hook where Carter's jacket hung half-lost in shadow, his hand slipped in and out of the chest pocket, quick as a card trick.

The ticket stub. Their mother's rusted ink. *If it comes back before I do —*

He was up the stairs before the fridge finished its rattle.

In the kitchen, Ava kept her eyes on the empty hallway a beat too long, sketchbook forgotten on her knee. She'd seen it. She always saw.

♦

The carnival at full glow was a beautiful thing, and that was the trap of it.

Strung lights swaying warm over the striped tents. The calliope playing its almost-right tune. Families streaming in through the gate, sugared and laughing and alive, and over all of them in the bulbs the same patient promise: ONE NIGHT ONLY.

Leo rolled up on his bike out of breath, shoes untied, and dropped the kickstand and looked up. And kept looking up.

A grin arrived on his face before he had any say in it — and then he caught himself and wiped it off with his sleeve, quick, like somebody might have seen a thirteen-year-old be happy and hold it against him.

The teenage worker manned the booth, silver stars freshly repainted, eyes as old as ever. Leo dug out his crumpled bills — and then, instead, laid the ticket stub down on the counter. His mother's ink faceup.

The worker went still. Stopped smiling.

"Where'd you get this."

"It's my mom's. She —"

"We honor old tickets." Warm, from the dark beyond the booth light. And Gideon stepped into it.

He picked up the stub. Read the back. And for one unguarded second there was no showman in him anywhere — just an old man holding a scrap of paper like it was a pulse he'd lost track of years ago and never stopped listening for.

"You'd be the youngest," Gideon said, the smile coming back up over his face like water finding its level.

"You knew her?"

The old man looked at the boy. *Really* looked. Somewhere behind the warm eyes something ran a piece of arithmetic and plainly hated the answer it came to.

"The carnival keeps what the world forgets, son. Every ticket. Every name."

"...Every name?"

"Even the things you lost." He leaned in, gentle — gentle as a hook going in.

"Like what?" It was barely more than air.

"That depends on what you're missing."

He slid the stub back across the counter with two fingers, and sent a fresh ticket along with it. The worker tore it, handed it over, and let their fingers touch — a small static spark jumped the gap.

"Welcome back," the worker said, quiet, and his eyes were on the stub and not on the boy at all.

Leo took the ticket and let the music and the color reel him in.

Gideon watched him go. Not smiling now. Nothing on his face at all.

And the worker wasn't watching Leo. The worker was watching Gideon — watching, specifically, the ink stains dark on the old man's fingers. Gideon felt himself being read and put the hand in his pocket.

"Do you know whose son that is," the worker said.

"Yes."

A long nothing. The calliope filled it with something that was trying very hard to sound cheerful.

"Open the tent," Gideon said. Not unkind about it.

♦

Behind the book tent, where the music arrived secondhand and warped through the canvas, Gideon slipped between the ropes and stopped in the dark — as alone as a man gets in a place where the walls can read.

He reached under his coat and found a locket, worn gold, and held it like a wound. Opening it cost what it always cost. One second. A woman's face.

He shut it before it could charge him more than the one second, and put it away.

"It's always somebody's," he said. To nobody. To the tent.

Then he straightened his coat, and went to work.

♦

Back at the house, Ava pushed Leo's door open with a single knuckle and leaned in.

"Leo. Truce. I brought you actual food —"

The room answered for him. Window open, curtain breathing on the cold coming through. Shoes gone.

On the pillow lay the carnival poster, and across the bottom of it, one word in pencil, pressed hard enough to groove the paper: *SORRY.*

Ava didn't move. For exactly as long as it takes a person to forget how breathing works.

"No, no, no —"

She took the stairs like a controlled fall. Carter was already up off the couch.

"He's gone. Window's open and his bike's gone. He *went.*"

"What —"

She shoved the poster into his chest. He read exactly one word of it and reached for his jacket — and then stopped. Patted the chest pocket.

Empty.

"He took the ticket."

"What ticket? What are you talking about?"

"Mom's." Already out the door.

"What do you *mean*, Mom's —"

The door slammed on the question.

♦

Leo moved through the lights and the sugar-smell and the noise, grinning now, openly, no sleeve to wipe it away. Tonight, finally, he got to be a kid — so he was one.

Then the calliope changed key. And under it, under all of it, something called to him. He turned toward it without deciding to. It felt less like walking than being reeled.

Ahead stood a tent smaller than the rest, tucked in between the bright ones like a held breath. Its fabric was darker. Stars were stitched into it in a thread that moved whenever he wasn't looking straight at it. And on the flap: a feather, inside a circle of ink.

Leo's hand went to his chest on its own. Against his skin the feather was humming like a struck tuning fork.

A rope hung across the entrance, and a sign: DO NOT ENTER.

The flap curled open by itself. The rope dropped.

He looked back once — the bright midway, the crowds, the whole normal world still right there where he'd left it, still available. Then he took a breath about the size of a decision, and he ducked inside.

♦

The inside was vast. Wrong-vast. Bigger than any tent had a right to be, and empty, except for a pedestal standing alone in a single column of moonlight — though there was no hole above it to let any moon in.

On the pedestal, the Book.

It waited there, bound in leather gone the color of old rain, its inscriptions shifting whenever they decided nobody was reading them. Locked, with no lock anywhere on it.

"Okay," Leo whispered. "Okay okay okay."

He crossed the floor the way you cross toward a sleeping animal, one careful foot set down after another, the feather at his chest burning brighter with every step of it.

"My mom had a ticket," he told the Book, and felt stupid the second it was out.

The Book opened itself.

Pages turned — too many of them, too fast — and stopped. On a blank page. Waiting.

And into the silence came a whisper made out of paper, a rustle in the shape of a word.

Name?

Leo's mouth came open.

"Le —"

"*Leo!*"

Carter came through the tent flap at a dead run and had Leo's arm and was hauling him back — Ava a half-step behind him —

— and Leo's palm came down flat on the blank page.

The ink came up. Off the paper. It rose to meet all three of them at once, wherever their skin touched: Leo's hand on the page, Carter's grip on Leo's arm, Ava's fist knotted in the back of Carter's coat.

The light didn't flash.

It turned. Like a page.

And the tent, and the music, and the whole world outside the canvas went over with the turning of it —

♦

EPISODE TWO

Every Image Has a Price

♦

Sound came back before anything else did — the calliope, except it was playing backward now, the notes dripping in reverse like water finding its way up a drain.

The three of them lay sprawled on the midway. The *same* midway. And that was the worst part, that it was the same.

Except.

The strung lights hung unlit in the air, motionless, like fireflies somebody had caught and frozen. The tents leaned at angles that hurt to look at directly, angles a tent had no business holding. And overhead there was no sky. Where the stars should have been there were *pages* — a ceiling of them, vast and slow-turning, wheeling without any wind to move them. Off to one side the Ferris wheel turned too, riderless, in perfect silence, going around and around for nobody at all.

Carter came up first, scrambling, dragging Leo behind him by a fistful of hoodie.

"Ava? *Ava* —"

"Here." She was already sitting up. "I'm here."

"You okay?" He had both of them by now, one hand on each. "Look at me. Both of you. Are you okay?"

They ended up standing close without deciding to, three of them in a ring, backs together, facing out. It was old instinct and nobody had ever taught it to them.

"This is it," Leo said, small. "This is the place from my —"

"Don't." Carter didn't let him finish. "Don't say dream. Just — don't."

Down the midway, a games booth stirred.

Something shuffled out from behind the counter of it. A man, more or less — a man made out of smudged pencil-lines, his face half rubbed away, like a drawing somebody had started to erase and then lost the heart for. A scrap of paper floated at his eye level, patient as a waiter. As they watched, a single line wrote itself across the scrap: *Sign here, and rest.*

The man reached out. Touched it. His mouth moved around something — a name, worn down to almost nothing, just the ghost of the shape of one.

And then he smoothed away. There was no other word for it. Like a thumb dragged through wet ink. Where he had been standing there was nothing, and the scrap that had held his name floated up and up and filed itself neatly into the turning pages overhead.

Nobody wanted to say the word *afraid*, so nobody said anything at all.

"Okay." Ava's voice was very level, the way a table is level right before something rolls off it. "What just happened to that man?"

"He gave it his name."

They spun.

Perched on the rim of a dead popcorn cart sat a creature about the size of a big dog. Part velvet and part copper, by the look of him. Moth wings, torn at the edges and laced all over with tiny writing, folded down his back like a coat that had seen better decades. His chest gave off a faint glow — a coal that had decided, against all advice, not to go out. And his eyes were too kind for the rest of him by a wide margin.

"Names are the only thing in here that's really yours," he said. "This whole place runs on them." He hopped down off the cart and gave them a bow, courtly and completely ridiculous. "Don't give it yours."

Carter stepped in front of his brother and sister. "What are you?"

"Hungry, mostly."

Then the creature saw the glow coming through Leo's shirt, and his wings went still.

"Where did you get that." It wasn't a question anymore.

"It's mine." Leo's hand went to his chest. "I've always had it."

"No. Before you."

He shook it off — literally, a puff of ash lifting off his wings — and hopped a half-turn away, like a man deciding not to open a door.

"Later. Later-later. Right now: you're leaking."

"Okay, no." Ava's arms came up. "We are not *leaking*."

"New pages leak. Memory, mostly. This place will drink you slow and call it reading." He unfolded one wing and pointed with it, down the length of the midway. "And that —"

Down at the far end of it — impossibly far, the distance stretched wrong, like a hallway in a bad dream — something waited. A big top, black-striped, and it was *breathing*, the canvas swelling and sinking. The pennant flag at its peak wrote and rewrote itself, over and over, never settling.

"— that is where it's writing yours. Three pages. Started the second you touched down." The wing folded back. "When the sun comes up out there, this chapter closes. Whatever's written, stays written. Forever-stays."

"Then we tear them out," Carter said.

"That's a terrible plan. Hide. Hiding works. I've been not-finished for years, because nobody can ever find —"

"Okay. Okay. Hiding. Until we know more." Carter was already three moves ahead, rebuilding the night into a plan. "Where —"

"No."

They both looked at him. Leo hadn't taken his eyes off the big top the whole time.

"Hiding is how this family does everything." He turned to face them. "We tear them out before dawn."

Ava's mouth twitched — the first almost-smile since the crossing. "He gets one good line a year," she said. "That was it. That was the line."

Above them the great pages turned. Slow. Patient. Like something settling in to read.

♦

They went in a tight knot down the center of the midway — Carter in front, Leo in the middle, Ava sweeping the back. The creature trotted alongside with the put-upon air of a cat that has agreed, under protest, to escort tourists.

"For the record," he said, "I'm not helping. I'm walking in the same direction."

"You're helping," Ava said. "You know that, right?"

"I'm *adjacent.*"

The carnival went on being wrong all around them. A ring-toss booth where every bottle held a tiny lit scene — a birthday in one, somebody's kitchen dance in another, each little life flickering behind the glass. A duck-shoot gallery where the ducks watched back. And drifting between the stalls, the smudged people, the erased ones. Some of them sweeping. Some queuing for rides that would never start. One tipped his half-gone hat to the kids, polite as a Sunday. In the dark between the booths there were more of them, standing, waiting for nothing anybody could name.

"They're people," Leo said, quiet.

"They were readers. Then they were characters. Now they're waiting."

"Waiting for what?" Carter asked.

"Whatever the Book does with pages it's finished."

Nobody asked the follow-up. Nobody wanted the answer at that hour of the night.

Leo slowed at one of the jar-scenes as they passed it — a woman braiding a girl's hair, the same three seconds over and over. He stopped.

"Rule of the road, small one." The creature tugged his sleeve, and for once it was gentle. "If something in here calls you by name, you keep walking."

Then, up ahead of them, the midway lights began to die.

One string at a time. Far to near. Each strand going dark with a small glass *tink*, like a mouth of teeth clicking shut, one after another, coming their way.

The creature clamped his wings flat to his body. When he spoke again there was no comedy left anywhere in it.

"Off the path. *Now.*"

♦

They dove behind a dead ride's gate and crammed themselves into a swan boat built for two people in love. Chipped paint. A drift of old ticket confetti gone soft in the seat well. Painted over the mouth of the tunnel in fairground gold: THE TUNNEL OF STORIES — EVERY RIDE A ROMANCE.

Nobody breathed.

Through the slats of the gate they watched the midway go black. And then it came.

The Hunter.

Low and long and wrong. A body like a wasp's nest, if a wasp's nest were built out of torn pages and stitched together with red thread gone brown at the knots. Legs that folded too many times on their way to the ground. And no face — just a seam, running the whole height of it, top to bottom, breathing open and shut, open and shut. It paged forward, and every step was a dry riffle of paper.

Leo huddled lower in the swan, his hand fisted around the feather through his shirt. Carter barred an arm across his chest, a seatbelt made out of brother. Ava had gone completely still, statue-still.

Out in the open, caught on the bare midway, stood a forgotten woman. Apron and oven mitts and half a face left to her.

She pleaded. You couldn't hear the words. You could only see the shape her mouth made trying to say them.

The seam opened.

It took her name first — you could tell, because her mouth kept moving and nothing came out of it anymore, the sound cut off at the root. And once the name was gone the pleading stopped mattering to anyone, including, somehow, her. She folded up like laundry and was filed away into the nest of pages.

Silence. Then, going off down the midway, the Hunter spoke. In her voice. Warm and floury and completely stolen.

"Suppertime," it said, to nobody. "Suppertime..."

The lights came back one string at a time, and the midway went on pretending nothing had happened. Somewhere the calliope picked up again mid-note.

In the swan boat, nobody moved for a long time.

"I would like to go home now," Ava said finally, very evenly.

"That's the spirit." The creature was recovering himself. "Homes. Hiding. Doors with locks —"

"What is that thing?" Carter said.

"The Book sends it for pages that run." A beat. "It doesn't read you. It collects you."

"It took her voice," Leo said.

"It takes whatever it can carry."

Leo climbed out of the swan on legs that didn't quite trust him and looked down the long wrong length of the midway, to where the big top's silhouette sat patient at the end of everything.

"Before dawn," he said. To himself. A promise.

♦

The creature led them along the edge of the games row at a trot, wings half-spread for balance, muttering a route to himself.

"Backlot to the boneyard, boneyard to the picture wagons, the *long* way around the wheel — slow, yes, boring, yes, alive, also yes —"

"How long?" Carter asked.

"Most of the night."

"We don't have most of the night."

Carter had stopped at a service gate wedged between two stalls, looking down. Set into the ground there was a ramp, sloping away under the funhouse, and at the bottom of it a workman's door in cheap plywood, stenciled CREW ONLY — LOWER WORKS. Cold air breathed up out of the seam of it, and there was frost furring the plywood on what should have been a warm night.

"No," said the creature.

"It goes under. Under is straight. Straight is fast."

"Nothing under this carnival is a shortcut. The lower works are where it keeps the —"

"That *thing* is up here." Carter's jaw was set. "Walking around wearing somebody's voice. I'm not marching them past it again. We go under, we come up past the wheel, we're at the tent before it knows we moved."

The creature turned to Ava for backup. She looked at her brothers — Leo gray to the lips with exhaustion, Carter vibrating with the need to *do* something, anything — and she made the call.

"Fast means less time for anything to find them." Then, off the creature's stare: "Us. Find us."

His wings sagged. A small thing surrendering to a committee. "On your heads," he said. "Which I will miss. All three heads."

Leo didn't say anything. He watched Carter haul the plywood door open onto the cold — and against his chest the feather pulled *backward*, toward the midway they were leaving. A small, urgent tug, like a hand catching his sleeve. He looked at the dark ramp. His brother was already three steps down it. So he followed his family down into the cold, one step after another, the feather pulling the other way on every single one.

♦

For the first fifty feet it was an honest service tunnel — struts and cables and a maintenance ladder, the plain bones of a place. It did not stay honest.

Fifty feet in, the plywood and pipe gave way to something much older. Galleries of packed paper, whole strata of a million torn ticket stubs pressed into stone, seams of dried ink veining the walls like coal. Ride gears the size of doors, half-buried in the rock, still turning their slow forever turns. And chalk marks everywhere — tallies, names written and crossed out, some of them crossed out very, very hard. Over the top of the tallies, in an older chalk gone amber, somebody's steady hand had written: EVERY IMAGE HAS A PRICE.

"People were counting something down here," Leo said, reading the walls.

"Days, probably. Don't read the names."

Leo could have sworn one of the crossed-out names darkened as they passed it. Nobody read the names.

They went down a switchback of scaffold stairs, out past the world's hearing. Forty feet up, the whole carnival had gone to rumor. Ava came last, trailing one hand along the wall — and the wall *liked* it. The ticket-strata rippled faintly under her fingers, following her touch the way iron filings crawl after a magnet. She snatched her hand back. Said nothing. Filed it away with everything else she wasn't saying.

At the bottom the stairs opened into a junction gallery — three tunnels, and a cold light that came from no source at all.

And then the floor read her.

Chains came up out of the packed paper, link after link surfacing fast and wet with ink, and snapped shut around Ava's wrists, her waist, hauling her down to her knees before anyone understood it was happening.

"*Ava!*"

Carter lunged for the chains and grabbed and pulled and accomplished exactly nothing. Leo was on her other side, prying, shouting. And across Ava's forearm, dragged by no hand at all, letters began to carve themselves into her skin — molten gold, beautiful and obscene, one after another:

S I L E N T G U A R —

"*No!*" Ava was screaming it now. "I said *no* —"

The letters did not care.

"Stop yelling —" The creature circled, frantic. "You can't out-yell a *sentence* — it's fitting you, it found a shape it likes and it's *fitting* you —"

"Then how do I make it *stop?*" Through her teeth.

"You unwrite it! But —"

Her hand moved before the *but* could land. Not thinking. It found the surface of the chain — and the chain *had* a surface, a skin like a page — and her finger dragged one hard line straight across it, the exact motion she'd used to cross out a thousand bad drawings.

Smoke came off the line. Everything around it went still and held.

"It takes." The creature had gone quiet and fast and honest. "Everything you make down here is paid for in what you remember. A real one. It chooses — unless you choose first."

The chains tightened and dragged the sigil one more letter down her arm.

Ava looked at Leo. At Carter. She did exactly one second of arithmetic — the same arithmetic she'd been running since the crash, the one where the number always came out of her own column.

"Dad's laugh," she said, steady. "Take Dad's laugh."

"Ava, *no* —"

She finished the line.

There was a breakpoint, clean across the chains. They didn't shatter. They *unhappened* — link after link sucked backward down into the floor like a sentence deleted mid-word. And the sigil on her arm died half-carved, the gold cooling to a scar:

S I L E N T G U A R —

and no more. Not ever.

Ava knelt there holding her own arm. The gallery was very quiet.

"Hey. Hey." Carter crouched down to her level. "What did it —"

"Say something Dad used to say."

"What?"

"Say it like him." It wasn't a request. "The thing about the ladder."

Carter didn't understand. Leo did. He delivered it small and dead-on, the impression landing exactly:

"'I've met smarter ladders.'"

They all waited while Ava's face did something terrible. She remembered *that* it was funny. She had the shape of the joke, the kitchen, the paint on his hands — all of it. The sound of him laughing was just not there. A tooth gone from the world, and her tongue kept going to the gap.

"Huh," she said, very quietly. Then: "It's like a word on the tip of your tongue. Except it's never coming."

Nobody had anything for that. Leo reached over and held her sleeve — not her hand, her sleeve, the way he had when he was five. She let him.

"You chose first," the creature said, soft. "Most don't."

Then his ears, such as they were, went up.

Far back up the tunnel, at the very edge of hearing: a dry riffle. Pages, folding too many times.

"Oh. Yes. It felt that." His wings snapped open. "Unwriting is *loud*. Everybody up. *Up!*"

♦

Running.

They pelted through halls of half-buried machinery, vaulting ink seams, ducking under gears grinding their slow forever turns — and behind them the riffle kept multiplying, closer, coming from nowhere and everywhere, the sound of a whole library falling down a staircase.

The creature rounded a corner and skidded to a stop. Not a dead end — a choke point. A gap between two titan gears, wide enough for children, far too tight for anything built like a wasp's nest.

"Through! Small ones first — *go* —"

Carter shoved Leo through the gap, then Ava, and turned back for the creature —

— and the Hunter poured around the corner.

Close, it was worse. The seam parted and sealed, parted and sealed, and stolen voices leaked out of it in a wet chorus — *suppertime, hold still, such a good boy* — a dozen kitchens and bedtimes all robbed and stitched together.

The creature planted himself in the gap, wings flared to make himself as big as a small thing can, and did the bravest thing his little life had ever offered him the chance to do.

"Fun fact!" he called back to the kids, bright and fast. "Things without names belong to nobody — which means, legally speaking, I am *luggage* —"

The seam yawned wide.

And he began to fray. Edges first — the tips of his wings lifting away in curls of ash-velvet, streaming toward the seam. He dug in his claws and was dragged anyway, his fur unravelling into loose thread, the coal in his chest guttering down toward dark. He looked back at Ava and tried, courtly to the very end, to bow in the middle of coming apart.

"It's been," he managed, "an unusually good day —"

"*No.*"

Her hands were on him. She didn't remember crossing back through the gap. Both hands, buried in fur that was trying to stop being fur. And Ava did the thing nobody had ever taught her.

"Your name is *Brim.*"

It struck like a bell in a stone room.

Every loose thread of him snapped home at once. Fur reweaving, wings slamming back into being fuller than they'd been, edged now in new gold script. In his chest the coal caught, and blazed.

The Hunter recoiled — actually recoiled, its pages shuffling backward, the seam cinching tight, thrown by the shape of a thing that now, blazingly, *belonged* to someone. It went still. And then, deliberately, horribly, the seam parted a half-inch, and from somewhere inside came a small dry sound.

A pen. Writing. Four letters' worth.

Then the Hunter folded itself backward into the dark and was gone, and it took every stolen voice with it.

Silence, except the gears grinding on.

Brim sat down hard on the floor of the gap, half in and half out and entirely undone, and stared at her.

"You named me."

"You were coming apart." Ava was still catching up to herself. "What was I supposed to do?"

"You *named* me. Nobody names things like me. Things like me are furniture. We're *weather* —"

"Brim."

He stopped. "...Yes. That."

He composed himself. Sat up straight. And bowed — the same courtly, ridiculous bow from the popcorn cart, except this time there was nothing ridiculous in it at all.

"A name given in love anchors," he said, quietly. "A name taken in fear owns." A beat. "Yours was the first kind. I would know. I've heard the other."

Leo watched him and filed that last sentence away, the way Leo filed everything.

"Why Brim?" he asked.

Ava opened her mouth. Closed it. She dug into her jacket and came up empty — her sketchbook was a whole world away, on her bed, in a house behind a locked front door. So she told it instead.

"There's a drawing in every sketchbook I've ever had. Torn wings. A lit-up chest." She looked at him. "Since I was little. And under the first one, in kid handwriting: *Brim.*" A beat. "I thought I made you up."

Brim went very still. The coal in his chest ticked like a cooling engine.

"…What an interesting family you are," he said, carefully.

He looked at the feather glowing through Leo's shirt. Then back at Ava. And he gave them exactly half of something.

"I knew someone who wore that."

Then he trotted ahead to scout, fast, before anyone could see whatever was happening in his kind and tired eyes.

Carter and Leo traded a look over Ava's head and came up empty. Neither of them had the word for it either.

The word was *before.* Nobody said it.

♦

EPISODE THREE

Out for Writing

♦

The last stair ended at a door. Real wood, real hinges — strange things to find down here. Brim set one paw against it and stopped them all with it.

"Through here is the only way up." There was no joke left anywhere in him. "Walk soft. And whatever you feel — feel it quietly."

He pushed it open.

And the world got big.

A cavern of shelves. Higher than weather, longer than the town they'd been born in. Shelf on shelf on shelf, rising up out of a lantern-colored dusk until the topmost rows blurred into a sky of their own. And every shelf packed tight with bound books.

The spines rose and fell. Barely. All of them together.

Breathing.

Ink-motes drifted up past their faces. Ava's hand found Carter's sleeve without either of them noticing it happen. Nobody said anything. Leo just looked, and looked, and looked — a boy getting the one thing the night still owed him. Wonder. The real kind. The kind that used to live in their house, back before the house learned to be quiet.

"What are they?" Ava whispered.

Brim didn't answer for three full steps.

"Everyone it ever finished." A beat. "This is the only room I'm quiet in."

They walked the canyon floor between the shelves, small as punctuation. And then Leo slowed. At his chest the feather pulled — not backward this time. *Up.*

His eyes climbed the wall of spines. Ten shelves. Twenty. To a place the lantern-dusk barely reached.

A gap.

One book's worth of empty space, in a cavern that had room for everyone who had ever lived. A little brass rail where a spine should have sat. Nothing on it. Nothing near it.

Leo stared up at the missing book until Carter's hand landed on his shoulder. Nobody explained it. Nobody could. Somewhere deep in the stacks a single page fell, soft as snow landing on snow, and Brim's ears went up. Time to move. At the far end, a run of iron rungs climbed toward a trapdoor set into the ceiling of the world.

♦

They went up the rungs and through, and surfaced into a mirror maze.

Except.

Every mirror was a bookcase with a glass front. And in every pane, your reflection came back to you spine-out — a book with your face on it.

After the Stacks, nobody gasped. Down there had been everyone else's endings. Up here, in the glass, were theirs.

Leo stopped mid-step and stared, because behind his own glass there was nothing. A gap on the shelf. And under the gap, a little brass plate, engraved in carnival copperplate: OUT FOR WRITING.

"Where's mine?"

"Being written." Brim didn't meet his eyes. "You know where."

Ava's reflection was a book with her face on the spine, wrapped in fine gold chain, caught halfway through some change — half the cover already gone to a flat stone gray. She looked at it. Touched the scar on her forearm. Said nothing, and said it louder than anyone in the room.

And Carter found his.

CARTER LONDON, on a spine, in tall proud letters, sitting alone on its shelf. A ribbon marked a place about two-thirds of the way through. And one thing more: the glass front stood ajar.

"Don't." Brim's warning came low. "Nobody reads their own and stays the size they were."

"I'm not reading ahead." Carter already had it open. "Just today. I want to see what it thinks today was."

The page at the ribbon was writing itself as he watched — handwriting appearing live, unspooling left to right, putting him down in ink: *...opened the book although the creature warned him, for the eldest Londo—* His mouth went dry. It was writing him *now*, his pulse turned to script.

And then his eyes flicked up. One line above today. Whatever was written there, his face did something none of them had ever seen it do.

Recognition.

The line held something he already knew. Something with the crash in it. Something with the word *mother* in it — and his thumb came down over the word fast, the way you'd squash a bug, and he slammed the book shut.

The whole hall of glass fronts rattled in their frames.

"What. What was it?" Ava said.

"Nothing." Too fast, too flat. "It's a prop. Fun-house junk." He was already moving. "Rides are down that way. Let's go."

He left it there and walked, and Ava followed watching his back with a brand-new suspicion. Leo didn't move at all. He studied his brother's book, the ribbon, the ajar glass — and then his own empty gap on the shelf — and then Carter, walking off with a lie sitting square across his shoulders.

"He does that," Leo said to Brim, barely a breath. "When it's about Mom, he does exactly that."

"Mm." Brim kept it just as quiet. "Runs in the family, I'd say. The doing-exactly-that."

They fell into single file and threaded a hundred angled versions of themselves. Down at the end of the hall, through one warped pane, was the way

out — the far end of the midway, and the big top nearer now, its breathing audible even through glass. And along the horizon-seam of the page-sky, faint as a bruise, ran a line of pale gold.

Dawn. Out there. Starting to think about it.

♦

One last row of glass stood on the way out — warped panes, silvered wrong. And in the middle pane, there was no reflection at all.

There was the ticket booth. The real one. The real world, lamplit and easy, on the far side of the glass like a shop window at Christmas. Gideon at the counter, mid-pitch, sliding a fresh ticket across to a night customer — a tired man with two kids asleep in the truck behind him.

Gideon looked up. Through the pane. At three children on the wrong side of everything.

He saw them see him. And Gideon Marr tipped his hat, and tore the ticket anyway.

The pane fogged from the far side, like breath on cold glass, and then it was gone — just warped silver and their own faces looking back. Carter put his body between the pane and his brother, and they walked.

♦

Cutting between the funhouse and the great dead wheel ran a row of picture wagons — circus caravans with painted sides, landscapes and seasides and ballrooms, each one a little too deep to be paint. They moved fast and quiet along the row, keeping to the shadows, Brim counting wagons under his breath like rosary beads to keep them honest.

"Don't look at the pictures," he said. "The pictures look back, and then they get *ideas* —"

Leo stopped walking.

Because the last wagon in the row didn't have a painted seaside on it.

It had their front door.

Exact. Right down to the paint chip at knee height, the brass number, the bell that had never worked. Warm light spilled out under it, the color of every winter evening that had ever gone right. And through the little window beside it, a kitchen. *Their* kitchen — before. Clean and bright, a radio playing somewhere. A woman's silhouette at the stove, her back turned, her hair down.

Humming.

"Mom?" Barely there.

"Leo." Carter's voice climbed. "Leo, *don't* —"

Leo was already at the steps. Nobody remembered seeing him cross the distance. Up close he could almost hear words inside the humming, and the silhouette swayed the way she used to sway when she cooked, on the good nights, the two-songs-on-the-radio nights. And sliding out from under the door,

neat as a hotel bill, came a page — blank, except for one word in that patient copperplate.

Name?

Growing up out of the wagon's wood beside it, like a stem, was a pen. Black. Patiently helpful.

"Small one." Brim's voice was low and it was urgent. "That door is a mouth."

Leo didn't hear him. Leo was watching the silhouette, and his hand was picking up the pen, and the pen fit his hand the way nothing had fit for two years. He pressed it down and wrote an *L*. And heard the humming climb a note — warmer, closer. He wrote an *E* —

And Carter's boot came down through the page.

Carter grabbed the doorframe in both hands and wrenched, and the whole wagon face gave way like scenery, which was all it had ever been. Flat painted boards crashed down into the mud, the warm light dying to a work-lamp on a cord. The silhouette was a smear of brown paint, woman-shaped if you needed it to be. For one beat longer the humming plinked on — a cheap music box, nailed inside the boards, winding down — and then there was nothing. Silence in the backlot.

"She was right there," Leo said.

"That was not her." Carter was breathing hard. "That was bait, Leo. That was a worm on a hook shaped like —"

"You didn't even *look*."

Leo heard the size of what had just been taken out of him — two years' worth — and even he looked surprised by it.

"You never look. You decide what's real and then that's it, that's the family policy, and if it hurts too much it isn't *real* —"

"Because one of us has to —"

He caught it. Too late. Everyone in the backlot could finish that sentence. Nobody did.

Ava stepped in between them, touching neither, and planted herself. "Hey. *Hey.* Not here. It's listening, and you two are giving it *material*."

She was right and they knew it. The brothers came apart, breathing, not looking at each other. And Brim nosed through the wrecked boards and went very still. The torn page — the one with the *L* and the *E* on it, in Leo's own hand — lifted on a wind that wasn't blowing, up and over the wagons and off into the dark. Quick and direct, like a paper airplane with an address.

"...Half a name's still half a door," Brim said, to himself, watching it go. Nobody else had seen. He didn't have the heart to say it louder.

♦

They came out of the backlot at the base of the Ferris wheel, and stopped.

Because the wheel had stopped turning. Not slowed. Stopped. And everywhere across the plaza the Forgotten were kneeling — sweepers and

ticket-takers and the polite hat-tipper from the gate, all of them, foreheads to the boards, still as furniture. And mid-phrase, the calliope cut out.

Nothing in the world dared make a sound. Then, crossing the plaza, came slow footsteps on paper.

"Down. Eyes down." Brim was backing up, and he was small. "That's the Book's own hand. That's the Executioner —"

Kneeling wasn't offered. She was already there.

Tall. Composed. Her armor was stitched out of pages — thousands of them, layered like feathers on some terrible bird — and her mask was pale parchment, seamed and sewn, with nothing where the eyes should have troubled you most. At her hip hung a long knife that was also, somehow, a quill. She regarded the three children the way an editor regards a late manuscript.

"Three unfinished pages," she said. "Out past the margin."

She spoke in layers — formal, unhurried — and underneath it, faint, was something that had been a woman once.

"You," she said to Carter, "are the caretaker draft. You carry them like stones and call it love." And then she switched, mid-breath, into a man's voice, easy and warm, their father's voice, exact: "Isn't that right, buddy?"

Carter rocked back a step like he'd been struck. Ava caught his sleeve.

"Don't. It's the same trick as the wagon. It's the *same trick* —"

"And the shield draft." The mask had turned to Ava, and the voice was flat, her own register now. "Half-carved. Shields don't have to feel anything at all."

Ava pressed her sleeve flat over the half-carved scar — it was burning under the cloth — and didn't give it the satisfaction of a wince. Mostly.

Then the mask turned to Leo. And the Executioner knelt, her armor folding page by page, bringing that seamed blank face down level with a thirteen-year-old boy.

"Leo."

But it wasn't her voice. It was Sara's. Their mother's — whole, and warm, and alive, and pouring out of a paper mask three feet from his face.

Leo made a sound like something breaking off at the stem.

"Baby," the Executioner said, in Sara's voice. "It's so loud in here without you."

"Stop it," Carter said.

"A gift." Her own voice again now, to Leo, only to Leo. "One second of her, free. The rest is yours the moment you finish what you started at the wagon." A beat. "Two letters already. You have such careful handwriting."

Leo stood there shaking. At his chest the feather was a live coal. Behind him, straining against Ava's grip — against *Ava's* grip — Carter was one bad second away from something there'd be no coming back from.

And Leo, who could not outfight and could not outrun a single thing in this entire world, did the one thing he could do.

He asked.

"If it's really her voice…" He steadied himself on the next words. "…why do you need my name to give it to me?"

Stillness.

A half-degree tilt of the mask — the exact angle of someone caught mid-sentence by a child's question. And from somewhere beneath the stitched armor, once, softly: *tick.* One tick, from a watch that should not still have been running. The Executioner's gloved hand moved, almost, toward the sound. And stopped itself.

"Dawn is patient." She rose, verdict-flat again. "I am patient." She turned away. "You will tire before I do, little page. They always tire."

She walked, unhurried, parting the kneeling Forgotten as she went, and paused at the far edge of the plaza without looking back.

"Bring them true," she said. To no one. To something.

And out along the midway, farthest first, the lights began to die.

"Oh, I hate this plan," Brim said. "*Run.*"

♦

Running.

Down the games row, the lights dying to the left of them. Cutting between stalls, the darkness sliding in from the right. Every route going black except one. Brim skidded around a corner and pulled up short. Ahead of them lay a single lit alley between two canvas walls — narrow, inviting, the only brightness left in the world.

"It's not chasing us." The awful arithmetic landed on his face as he said it. "It's *herding* us."

"How does it keep *finding* us —" Carter started.

And Brim's eyes went to Leo's pocket. "It's not tracking feet. Half an *L* and half an *E*, singing out every step we take."

Leo's hand closed over the pocket.

"Then we go dark," Carter said. "Pick a black alley, any black alley —"

Behind them, close now, no longer bothering to pretend, came the dry riffle. And out of it, in a warm floury woman's voice: "Suppertime..."

"Lit alley," Ava said. "*Lit alley.*"

They took it at a dead sprint. Pounded down the canvas corridor with the walls breathing on both sides, the riffle right behind them now, pages folding and unfolding at a run. At the alley's end was a seam — a place where two great page-walls of the world didn't quite meet, a gap of raw unprinted dark, barely kid-width.

"Through!" Brim shouted. "It can't fold in there — nothing's *written* in there —"

Leo through. Carter through. Ava turned herself sideways at the gap — last, always last, always the rear guard —

And the Hunter took its swing.

One limb of packed pages, edge-on — a paper cut the size of a sword — came scything at her back —

And Brim was already there.

He leapt the way small brave things leap, and met the blow side-on. The page-edge caught him across the chest. Across the coal. And Brim cannonballed backward through the seam, spraying light — not blood, *light*, gold and guttering — out of a crack straight through the glow of him, into Ava, and the two of them tumbled together into the raw dark. Behind them the Hunter's limb slammed against the gap and could not follow. Nothing was written in there. It scrabbled at the edges of the seam, furious, a wasp at a window. And as they fell away into the unprinted dark, its voice — her voice — followed them, patient as ever.

"Supper... time..."

♦

Raw dark. Not empty — *unwritten*. The difference was loud. No echo when you stepped into it, just a soft taking-in, like the world keeping notes.

Ava knelt over Brim in the not-light, both hands pressed to his chest, gold leaking between her fingers.

"Brim. Hey. Look at me — you're okay, say something, give me a rule —"

"Rule one." He was woozy, and game. "Don't get hit." He coughed, and it came up gold. "See? Fine. All fine. Barely a paper cut."

"It *is* a paper cut," Leo said.

"It's a *thematic* paper cut."

Nobody laughed, and everybody nearly did, which was how this family loved anything at all.

Three steps ahead, Carter went rigid. Because the dark in front of them wasn't empty either. Strung across the seam, line after line, was thread — hundreds of strands, knotted and woven — wards, hung between the page-walls, every knot pinning down a tiny scrap of written paper.

"Thread-wards," Brim whispered, awed. A beat. "Only one person strings thread-wards."

"Wrong."

The voice came from everywhere — female, hard. A figure dropped out of the webbing above them and landed in a crouch, a blade already out: a long quill knife, broken and re-sharpened so many times it was mostly edge. Miren. Nineteen, hollow-eyed and unbroken, dressed in patched carnival canvas and thread, like she'd skinned the tents themselves for armor.

"Only one person *left*," she said.

The blade held all of them where they stood.

"New pages. Glowing like a signal fire, trailing the Hunter behind you, straight into the one place it hasn't found." Her voice was cold. "Give me a reason I shouldn't push all three of you back out through that seam."

"We're trying to reach the big top." Carter's hands were up, his voice level. "Before dawn."

"The *heart?*" She almost laughed. What came out had more scar tissue in it than a laugh. "Dawn shuts this chapter like a coffin lid, and the ones it's finished

writing just... stop being asked questions. That's survivable. I survive it every time." She jerked her chin at the dark around them. "You want to live? You stay in the seams. You get small. You let it finish its stupid sentence about you and you never, ever answer to it again."

"That's hiding," Leo said.

"That's *winning*, down here."

"Hiding is how this family does everything." He stepped past Carter, right up to the edge of the blade. "We're done. We tear our pages out before dawn."

Miren studied him over the top of her knife. A long second. A thirteen-year-old with bruised eyes, talking about tearing pages out of the Book of endless stories.

And then her eye caught on something else. The feather — slipped free of Leo's collar in the chase, gray-white and edged in black, glowing its low stubborn glow.

The knife wavered.

"Where did you get that." A different voice entirely.

"I've always —"

She moved before anyone could blink. Past the feather, straight for the thing that had fallen half out of his hoodie pocket when he'd raised his hands.

The ticket stub.

She turned it over with fingers that had started, very slightly, to shake. Read the rusted ink. *If it comes back before I do* — And you could watch the fight go out of her face as she read it. What was left underneath was younger, and it was afraid, and it was hoping, and on her those were the same expression.

"You're hers," she said. Barely.

She looked up and read them — Leo, Ava, Carter — three faces all at once, like pages.

"All three of you. You're *hers.*"

Her eyes flicked past them, to Brim. And Brim, for the first time all night, was not looking back.

♦

EPISODE FOUR

The Caretaker Draft

♦

Deeper in, the seam widened into a pocket of stolen comfort. A carousel horse with chipped gilt lay on its side for a bench. A lantern held a coil of caught inklight, glowing the color of late afternoon. A kettle stood by that had clearly been argued with.

And covering one entire page-wall: the archive.

Hundreds of scraps, pinned under thread-wards. Ticket halves. Napkin sketches. Single sentences torn off mid-line. Pieces of paper rescued the way you'd rescue living things.

Miren worked by the lantern, stitching Brim's cracked coal with ward-thread, quick and exact and unsentimental. Brim endured it.

"Ow."

"It's not through the glow. You'll keep."

"*Ow.*"

"Stitching's the one thing this place taught me. Hold still, or learn the second thing."

Leo and Ava and Carter sat in a row on the carousel horse, drinking something hot out of mismatched tin cups. Being children for thirty seconds. Nobody wasted it by saying so.

Miren tied off the thread and crossed to her archive wall and stopped in front of it. "How long ago," she said. "The crash."

"Two years in March," Carter said.

She nodded like a number had just balanced. She reached into the very center of the wall — past wards doubled and tripled — to the one scrap that lived behind all the others, and unpinned a single page. Her coat swung open with the reach, and for one second there was a pocket watch on her belt, old brass, wrong for everything else she owned. Nobody remarked on it. Ava clocked it.

The page was old. Torn down one edge. Carried and re-folded so many times the creases had gone soft as cloth.

"I've been guarding this for six years," Miren said. "I didn't know whose children would come for it."

She held it up where all three of them could see.

The page was a contract. Printed across the top in the Book's patient copperplate: THOSE WHO ESCAPE MUST ONE DAY RETURN — OR THE STORY COLLAPSES. And below that, one line, in a ledger's neat hand: OWED: ONE ENDING. And below *that* — a signature line.

Torn away. Ripped clean off the bottom of the page. What was left of the paper ended in a wound.

But above the tear, in the margin, someone had written a note in looping, rusted ink. The same hand as the ticket stub. The same hand as DO NOT THROW OUT.

Their mother's hand.

Not my children. — S.

"That's her writing," Leo said, barely. "That's — Mom wrote that."

"Sara London."

The name landed in the camp like something set down very carefully.

"First time I heard anyone say it out loud was the night she tore this page," Miren said. "I was thirteen. I watched her do it."

"You knew her?"

She turned the page in the lantern light, letting the torn edge catch gold. "For one night. It was enough to spend six years on." A beat. "The Book had her name. She signed it away the night I met her — to buy somebody a door out."

"A door for who?" Ava said.

A beat too long. "Me."

The camp held very still. Even the kettle.

"I'd been in a year by then. People sent in after me kept not arriving. She was the first stranger who did." Flat, like reading a receipt. "A woman I'd known one night bought me a door out of this place with her own name."

"Then why are you still here?" Ava said, quiet.

Miren took the question and turned it over and put it down. "The seams needed a keeper."

It was visibly not the whole answer, and nobody in this family was fool enough to miss that, and nobody was cruel enough to dig. A flicker crossed behind her eyes, fast, and was gone — a girl doing arithmetic about mothers.

"When it came to close her chapter, she took a knife and cut her name off her own debt."

Silence in the camp.

"She beat it," Leo whispered.

"The only one who ever did. It's had six years to forget how much it hates that. It hasn't."

"Okay." Carter's voice was doing something careful. "She tore her name off. So it couldn't touch her. So then what does any of this —"

"The debt doesn't die, London. *That's* the law. The whole law." She tapped the printed line. "'Owed: one ending.' It couldn't collect on her — no name, no handle. So the debt sat there. Open."

"...And?" Ava said, already dreading it.

Miren looked at the three of them. She hated this part and she did it anyway, level and slow. "An open debt with no name on it attaches to blood."

Silence. Nobody moved on the carousel horse.

"The carnival came back," Leo said, working it, refusing it. "It came back for —" And then he stopped. Because he was thirteen, not stupid, and the last piece went in with an almost audible click.

"'If it comes back before I do,'" Ava said, softly, reading it off the air.

"She wasn't leaving us." Leo looked up at Carter. "She was driving *back*. To sign something. So it couldn't come for —"

Crack. The tin cup in Carter's hand hit the floor.

He'd gone white. Not at the news. At something underneath the news — something that fit a shape he'd already seen, a line above today, in a book, behind glass.

"Carter." Ava was watching him, quiet and lethal.

"I'm fine."

"That's not what I said."

He didn't answer. He crouched and picked up the cup, careful, like the floor might be graded on it. Ava filed it, on a pile that was getting heavy.

"Route 17 runs past the fairground turnoff," Miren said. And then, as gently as she had it in her: "They were four minutes away."

Leo put both hands over his face. Not crying. Holding his face on.

"She was coming to pay it," he said, muffled, coming apart. "And I walked in the front door and almost *signed* —"

"Hey. No. No." Carter moved before anyone saw it — across the camp, crouched in front of his brother, both hands on his shoulders. For once he wasn't managing anything. He was just there, holding on. "It sent you an invitation, Leo. It hunted you. Thirteen-year-olds don't owe anything to anything." A beat, rough. "It doesn't get to have you. It doesn't get to have any of us. Okay?"

Leo dropped his hands and looked at his brother — surprised, sandbagged, grateful in a way that had nowhere to go.

From her side of the camp, quiet, Miren watched the three of them with an expression she'd have denied owning.

"Now you know what it wants," she said. "And it isn't the three of you, even." She held the page up between two fingers. "One. Paid in kind. One of you stays and gets finished — and the other two walk free, out the front gate."

"One," Ava said, flat.

Miren let that sit exactly as long as it deserved. "It's been making that offer all night, in every language it has. The house. The voice. The pretty pen."

"And at dawn?" Ava said.

"At dawn it stops asking. It picks."

The lantern-coil flickered. Somewhere beyond the page-walls, muffled, the calliope played its backward song for nobody.

♦

Round two with the kettle. Ava turned her ward-stitched sleeve over and over. Leo stood at the archive wall, at the pinned contract page, studying the torn edge at nose distance, the way he studied everything. Quiet held the camp — except for two brothers not talking to each other at a completely new frequency.

"You have until first light to get small," Miren said. "I've hidden nineteen people in these seams."

She lifted the lantern. And for one second the seams showed themselves: faces, back in the folds. A child, edges gone soft as a pencil smudge, watching Leo with enormous eyes. An old man mouthing a name with too few letters left in it. A woman holding a page to her chest like an infant. The lantern lowered, and the dark folded them away again.

"I can hide three more."

"Hide," Carter said.

She'd said it to all of them. She watched only Leo. "That's the offer. It's a good offer."

"And the debt?" Carter said.

"Stays open. Stays hunting. You get old in the dark and you never sign anything."

"That's not a life."

"It's the longest available argument."

Leo turned from the wall and faced them. "Or?"

"There's no *or*, little London. Nobody tears pages out of the Heart. Your mother was already standing at its table. You'd be walking in —"

"Three pages. Before dawn." Leo said it like he'd been holding it the whole night. "Nobody stays, nobody signs, nobody gets picked."

"You're insane."

"The debt wants an ending. It can have the one where it loses."

Miren stared at him. Thirteen years old, bruise-eyed, standing under six years' worth of rescued paper, saying the sentence she'd stopped letting herself say at fourteen.

"You'd never make the big top's shadow without me," she said.

"Probably not."

She looked at Ava, then at Carter, waiting for one adult-shaped objection.

"He gets two good lines a year, apparently," Ava said.

Carter stood up. "We're with him."

A beat. Miren exhaled through her nose — the sound of a very old argument losing to a very young one. She turned to her archive and started pulling wards down, coiling them around her fist, travel-rigging, fast and decided.

"Then we do it my way as far as my way goes. Seams to the boneyard. Nobody talks in the open. Nobody answers to a name in the open." The quill-knife went across her back, the strap cinched hard. "Nobody touches anything that knows them. And when it goes wrong — it will — you do what I say, when I say it."

"She's very warm once you get to know her," Brim offered, rising gamely, stitched and stiff.

"Nobody gets to know me."

She stopped at Ava on her way to the seam-mouth, though. Unwound one thread-ward from her fist and tied it, brisk and unasked, around Ava's wrist —

over the sleeve, over the scar. "For the half-carved thing," she said, not making it a thing. "It itches less."

Then she held out the ticket stub — to Carter. Not Leo. Carter. "Yours to carry."

Ava turned the new ward on her wrist. Every knot on that wall had the same quick twist — Miren's twist. Except one. Dead center of the archive, over the empty pin where the contract had lived, hung a ward in a different hand. Older. Finer. A knot like a signature.

"That one's not yours," Ava said.

A beat. "It was on the page when I found it."

"Whose is it?"

"Six years. I never found out." She said it the way you admit to the one thing in your own house you can't explain, and she was three steps gone before Ava could decide what her face was doing.

Leo stayed at the wall a last moment, taking one last look at the contract page — the torn wound where a name used to be, and his mother's margin note, small and furious and outnumbered. *Not my children. — S.* He touched the feather through his shirt.

"We'll finish the sentence," he whispered. To the page. To her.

Then he ducked out after the others, into the dark between the pages. Behind him the lantern-coil dimmed to ember. On the wall, the wards over the empty pin swayed. Settled. Went still.

♦

They came out of the seams into the place old rides go to die.

Carousel horses stacked like cordwood. A slide tower on its side. Half a Ferris wheel leaning against the page-wall like a giant's dropped coin. Everything tarped, roped, still. Miren led them through the junk canyons, one fist wrapped in ward-thread, reading the dark like a page she'd memorized.

"Boneyard's the last cover," she said, low. "Past the fence it's open midway to the tent. We cross fast, we cross quiet, and we touch *nothing* —"

She stopped.

Ahead, between the junk-stacks, was a glow. Warm. Wrong. Three windows — three tall show-booths standing free in the wreckage, the kind that hold wax scenes and mechanical fortune-tellers. Lit from inside. No dust on them. Waiting.

Miren's knife was out before her breath was. "These weren't here yesterday."

"They're not here *now*." Brim backed up a step. "Not really. It's stopped herding." A beat, grim. "It's *courting*."

Because each window had a name painted over it in fairground gold, and each window was playing a scene.

The first: THE MAN WHO HELD IT TOGETHER. Inside, tiny and perfect, a miniature Route 17 in the rain, a little car pulling over safe, a tiny woman in the driver's seat waving back at a porch where three children waved — and at the

head of a long table, an older Carter, sturdy and certain, carving at a dinner that never ended, everyone he loved seated, nobody ever leaving. Ever.

The second: THE GIRL WHO CARRIED NOTHING. Inside, a small Ava, maybe eight, riding on shoulders through a fair, hands sticky with sugar and holding nothing at all, every adult she loved alive and tall around her, and her whole job in the world just to be carried.

The third: THE BOY THE STORY LOVED. Inside, a book on a velvet stand, LEO LONDON embossed in gold on the cover, and through its open pages flickered scenes of a boy — wanted, certain, finished — a boy whose face never once wore the look of someone checking whether he'd ruined the room by walking into it.

Nobody spoke. Three pools of window-light, three siblings standing in them, each lit by their own private impossible thing.

"Eyes down," Miren said, quiet and urgent. "It's fishing. Walk away."

Nobody walked away.

Leo drifted half a step toward his window — and caught himself. Actually caught himself: grabbed his own sleeve, dug his heels in, looked *down.* Two hard-won lessons old. Ava stared at the small sticky-handed girl on the shoulders and let something in her face close like a book, and then she turned her back on it. First of the three to manage it.

"Nice try," she said, to no one, mostly to herself.

But Carter was at the glass. Both palms on it. Watching the little car pull over, again and again, the loop resetting, the little woman waving, safe, safe, safe. And in the glass, faint as breath, a reflection arrived beside his own. Gideon — standing somewhere else entirely, looking out at him. Nobody else could see it from their angle. The reflection lifted one finger to its lips.

"*London.*"

Miren's hand closed on his collar and hauled him back off the glass. All three windows guttered, their scenes flickering, sulking, going dim.

"What did I say." She was in his face. "What is the *one* thing I said."

"Touch nothing. I know." He was shaken, and covering it. "I know."

She stared him down a second longer. Released him. She moved off through the junk canyon, and didn't see what there was to see: Carter's hand, at his side, opening and closing. And his eyes going back, once, to the dark window, where for just a blink the glass held a light that wasn't there.

♦

Down at the south end, the lights had given up years ago. The rides stood in their tarps like furniture in a closed house. Gideon walked the boards slow, hat in his hands — a man visiting a grave he'd built himself.

She was already there. Of course she was. The Executioner, still as the rides, watching the dark the way lighthouses watch water. He didn't startle. You don't startle at weather you've lived under half your life.

"Evening," he said.

Nothing.

"It was always your shift. The quiet end."

"You are out past the margin, ticket-man."

"My margin. My gate. My name on the arch." He turned his hat in his hands, one full turn. Getting to it took the whole rotation. "Humor an old salesman. The debt. One ending, owed by the London line." A beat. "Owed by the line… or just owed?"

"The terms have not changed."

"That's not an answer."

A silence. And then — because law was the only language she had left to give him anything in — "An unsigned debt attaches to blood. A signed one belongs to the signature." A beat. "The ledger does not read blood, ticket-man. It reads ink."

"…Huh." One syllable. The flattest sound he'd made all night.

Silence. Tarps breathing in a wind that wasn't there. And then, from somewhere beneath the stitched armor, soft as a held thing: *tick.*

Gideon heard it. His eyes went to the exact seam the sound had come from. And away. Fast. The way you don't look at the sun. Neither of them mentioned it. The not-mentioning was the whole marriage.

"You could not say my name either, I suppose," he said, softer, not selling anything now. "If I asked."

"Names are surrendered or entrusted, ticket-man. Yours was neither."

"No. I kept mine." He put his hat back on. "It's been very good company."

He walked away down the dead boards and didn't look back. The mask pointed after him, which might have been all that watching was now. And her gloved hand, at her side, moved, almost, toward the tick. Stopped itself. And along the horizon-seam behind her, the line of gold thickened by one more thread.

♦

A pocket between a dead carousel and the boneyard fence. Through the slats: the open midway, wide and bright and terrible, and beyond it, closer than it had any right to be, the big top. Breathing, slow. Along the horizon-seam of the page-sky, the line of gold had thickened. Dawn, out there, clearing its throat.

Miren rigged thread across the fence gaps, fast. Brim slept in a tight coil, his coal-glow dimmed to a nightlight, his stitches rising and falling. Ava sat against the carousel with her ward-wrapped wrist on her knee. And Leo was out — truly out, folded sideways on the boards, hood up, finally too empty to stay scared. Thirteen for a minute.

Carter watched them all and counted, the way he'd counted for two years. One, two. Safe. Asleep.

He slipped away between the junk-stacks. Gone.

♦

Dead funhouse stock leaned in a row against a flatbed. Warped mirrors. Cracked mirrors. And one mirror, dead center, not cracked at all.

Carter stood in front of it. His reflection was wrong by one man. Gideon, in the glass, hat in his hands like a salesman on a porch.

"You saw the window," Gideon said.

"You put it there?"

"I *asked* for it. The difference is the last thing I own, if nobody else counts it."

"You've been watching us?"

"It shows the ending it's prepared to write you." Gideon stepped closer in the glass. "Nobody invents that little car. It read it off your ribs."

"Don't call me son."

"No. Fair." He turned his hat in his hands, one full turn. "The Book needs one of you to stay. It does not care which. That's the whole ugly sum of it."

"Get to it."

"You've already done this math, haven't you? You did it at the glass tonight."

Carter said nothing, which was an answer.

"You're eighteen. They're children. One signature on the caretaker's line, and they walk out the front gate before sunrise."

"And me?"

"You stay. You get finished."

"Finished," Carter said, flat.

"It's not death, if that helps." Gideon said it quietly. "It's more like... being decided."

"Both of them out. Untouched. Nothing follows them. Not the debt, not the Hunter, not you."

"Yes."

"And they don't watch. Whatever it is — being decided — they're gone first. They don't see it."

In the glass, Gideon's face did something complicated. Something almost like respect, if respect could be ashamed of itself. "You'd have made a good father, you know. Given the run of a normal —"

"Show me the line."

Gideon lifted his hand to the inside of the glass and summoned it like frost forming — a page. The contract, the printed law, and a fresh signature line, unsigned, waiting, with a small neat annotation: THE ELDEST.

Carter raised his hand to the mirror.

"*Carter.*"

Her hand closed on his wrist. Ava had come around the flatbed silent as a held breath, and she looked past him into the glass — at Gideon, at the page, at all of it — and her face did the thing where fury has to wait in line behind heartbreak.

"What are you doing? Take your hand down."

"Ava —"

"*Take it down.*"

He did. Slowly. In the glass, the page stayed. Patient. Gideon didn't move.

"Girl. Please." Gideon's voice was gentle, and dreadful. "I can save two of you. That's two more than anyone saved for me —"

Ava grabbed a half-brick off the flatbed and put it through the mirror.

Glass everywhere. Gideon and the page and the light gone into a hundred spinning pieces, raining across the boneyard mud. Silence. The kind with a burn to it.

"You don't understand what you just —" Carter started.

"A trade. I understand a trade." Ava's voice was climbing. "You were *signing*."

"I was getting you *out* —"

"You were *leaving.*"

That word cracked across the mirror row louder than the brick had.

"How is that the same?"

"Isn't it?" She was shaking now. "Mom left to save us. Look what it made."

"Ava."

"It's not love just because it costs you everything." She was barely holding on. "You don't get to die for us and call it taking care of us —"

"What trade?"

Small, from the end of the row. Both of them turned. Leo stood there, hood down, awake after all, and behind him Miren, knife out, eyes on the broken glass and the fence line — reading consequences while the family read wounds.

"What trade, Carter?"

"One of us signs. The other two walk." Carter made it as steady as he could. "I was going to —"

"You were going to disappear." Leo's voice was the coldest it had ever been. "And we were going to wake up *free*, and just — live? On that?"

Carter opened his mouth. Nothing came. Because there was no sentence that survived contact with his little brother's face right then.

"You'd be a page in that tent, forever, and you decided that was *fine*, and you didn't ask —" Leo's voice was breaking to pieces. "— you never *ask* —"

"Enough. All of you."

Miren crouched at the broken mirror and held one shard up to the lantern-light. In its corner sat a tiny image that shouldn't have been there: a stitched parchment mask, turning, finding its bearing.

"He touched a thing that knows him. The glass got his measure — which means the Book has your position, and the shapes of your *names.*" She stood, cold and fast, and snapped the shard away into the mud. "She's coming. The open midway just got shorter. Camp's burned. *Move.*"

Nobody moved like a family. They moved like four strangers who happened to be fleeing in the same direction. And behind them, in every shard scattered across the mud, the same tiny reflection stood patiently in a hundred pieces: an old man, holding his hat, watching the children run.

♦

Their way out ran back past the three windows. All three were lit again.

Miren pulled them up short, because the first window had been repainted.

Same gold title — THE MAN WHO HELD IT TOGETHER. Same endless dinner, same long table, same warm little world.

Set for three now.

Carter. Ava. And an empty stretch of tablecloth where nothing was missing — no gap, no fourth chair, no scar in the paint. A table that had never needed one. And under the title, in fresh copperplate, still wet:

REVISED TERMS: ONE REMAINS. TWO WALK. NONE REMEMBER.

Nobody breathed for a second.

"It raised," Miren said, reading it twice, flat.

"One of us stays." Ava worked it out loud, hating every word. "And the other two just — walk out. And don't remember there was ever a —" She stopped. Carrying that sentence to the end was beyond anybody standing in the boneyard.

Carter had gone grey. Because he'd done that math at the mirror an hour ago, and the answer had just changed shape.

"You wouldn't even have missed me," he said. Barely.

Nobody had anything for that. The window light guttered, satisfied, and died.

"*Move.*"

They crossed the last junk canyon at a run. And pulled up hard.

A Forgotten knelt in their path. Half through being smoothed away, hat still in its hands, the mud around it pressed flat in a wide, deliberate circle. Minutes old. She had been here. She was closer than the fence.

Nobody said her name. Walking faster was the whole conversation.

♦

EPISODE FIVE

Come Together

♦

A culvert of rolled tin, half-swallowed by mud and old tickets. Cramped. Safe-ish. Packed inside were the four of them and Brim, while Miren watched the boneyard through a rust-hole, thread wound tight around her fist.

Nobody had said a word for a while.

Carter sat alone at one end with the size of what he had almost done. At the other, hood up, gone somewhere inside himself, sat Leo. And Ava, in the middle, holding everyone's silence the way she had held every silence for two years, started, very quietly, to shake.

"Oh. Hey." Brim woke, soft. "Hey, now."

She shook harder. Not crying. Something with more pressure behind it than crying — the sound a dam makes just before, all of it held in the jaw.

"I broke the mirror," she got out, barely making the words. "I wanted to break *him.* And I can't keep being the one who —" Her breath wouldn't finish anything.

"Say the true one," Brim said.

"I didn't cry when they died. I didn't even scream."

There it was. Two years old, and never once said out loud. Even Miren, at her rust-hole, went still.

"Everyone got to fall apart except me." A whisper with everything underneath it. "I've been *fine* so long I don't remember what I'm like."

Brim uncoiled and crossed the culvert and put his small heavy velvet head against her collarbone, coal-warm.

"Then scream now," he said, gently.

"I can't. The midway — she'll hear —"

"Not out there." He nodded at the culvert's far mouth, where the tin opened into the raw dark of a seam. The unwritten. The place that absorbs. "In there, nothing carries. The world just takes it and keeps it." A beat. "Give it something to keep."

Ava looked at the dark. Then at her brothers — Carter wrecked, Leo hood-up and watching. She decided. She crawled to the seam-mouth, knelt, braced both hands on the tin.

And screamed.

Full. Two years long. And the unwritten dark took it — no echo, no evidence — the scream pouring out of her and into the raw black like water into sand, and it kept coming, and it kept coming, and when it finally stopped, the silence came back spent.

She stayed there, forehead against the tin, breathing like she'd run a mile. And then she started to laugh. Two seconds of wet, exhausted, alive laughter.

"Okay," she said, catching her breath. A beat. "Okay."

She crawled back and settled between her brothers, closer than before. Neither of them said anything. Leo leaned his head on her shoulder. And after a moment, glacial, Carter's hand found her boot and just held on.

Miren, at the rust-hole, had seen all of it — the scream, the laugh, the long settling after. Something in her face had come unlocked by half an inch. She took the pocket watch off her belt and opened it. Inside the lid, small and round, was a photograph: a man, a girl, a woman. Smiling. Looking at it lasted about as long as Ava's laugh had. Then she closed it, and it went back on her belt, and her face locked up again like weather changing its mind. She shared it with nobody.

Across the culvert, half-asleep, Ava saw the watch close. She said nothing. She always saw. She never said. Except once. Tonight, once.

"Six years hiding in his seams," she said, quiet, to the rust-hole and not to her. "You never once let him see you?"

Miren went still. The whole culvert waited to find out what her face would do about it.

"Letting him see me made me sellable. One more thing he could offer it." That was the practiced half. The rest arrived slower, and cost more. "And I couldn't forgive him the tickets. Watching was the only thing I could do that didn't cost anybody else." She turned back to the hole. Done. More words about herself than the seams had heard in six years.

Brim watched her settle, letting his coal-glow warm the tin around them. "That one the Book doesn't get," he said, mostly to himself. And then his glow faltered. Because Ava was looking at him now — at the stitched crack across his coal — and her face was putting numbers together.

"In the gears. It went for me. And you were already between us."

"Ah," Brim said, very quietly.

"Why did it swing at *you?*" Slow. Careful.

A long pause. His wings settled flat, the way they did when he was done being funny. "Because it heard your voice make me real."

"That's not an answer."

"You anchored me, small one. And a name, once given… can be *written.*" A beat. "It has mine now. Four letters, in its ledger. In your handwriting, more or less."

"I named you and it — what, it *owns* you now?" The horror was arriving.

"It can *find* me. Owning is a longer conversation."

"I made you *findable*."

"You made me *somebody.*" His kind, tired eyes held hers, and held, and did not blink. "I'd rather be named than be furniture — and I've *been* furniture. I know what I'm choosing." A beat, courtly to the bone. "You gave me the better half of the bargain. Don't you dare apologize for it."

Ava opened her mouth to apologize for it. Closed it. Nodded instead, jaw tight, and filed this one somewhere that wasn't the guilt pile. It fit badly. She kept it anyway.

"Gold's over the fence line," Miren said from the rust-hole. "Dawn's started climbing." She turned from the hole and let the edge drop, for once — just the flat accounting of someone who had watched a lot of dawns take a lot of things. "Whatever this family is when it's finished falling apart — be that, by the count of ten. Then we cross."

♦

They crossed the open ground in a tight arrow — Miren on point, the siblings behind her, Brim sweeping the rear. Fast, silent, exposed the whole way. Overhead the page-sky was paling at its seams, gold climbing the horizon-line like water finding a crack.

They made it halfway. Dead center of the midway, the worst possible place —

Every light on the midway died at once.

Not string by string. All of them. One breath, one great glass *tink*, and the world went black to the tent-line.

"*Down* —" Miren hissed.

And out of the dark, close, from no direction and every direction, came Sara's voice.

"Leo. Baby. Come here."

Leo stopped moving.

Every cell of him had done this math all night. His feet turned toward the voice anyway. Thirteen years, against one night of rules. No contest.

"Leo, it's *not* —" Ava, whisper-screaming.

"I found my ticket," Sara's voice said. "We can go home now."

One second. That was all it needed.

The dark folded open and the Hunter was there. One limb of packed pages took Leo around the chest and lifted him clean off the boards — no swing, no violence, almost gentle, the way you pick up a parcel that's already addressed.

"*Leo!*" Carter.

Chaos in the black. Carter charging. Miren's quill-knife out and slashing — the blade bit paper, carved a curl of limb away, and the limb re-folded around the wound like a book closing on a bookmark. Leo kicked, twisted, fought, the feather blazing under his shirt. And the Hunter simply held him higher, out of everyone's reach, a parcel on a top shelf. It turned toward the big top, and walked.

"Suppertime," said Sara's voice, fading, terrible.

"*No* — Leo —" Ava, running after it.

And the Hunter's second limb came around, edge-on, unhurried — a paper cut the size of a door — scything back at Ava and Carter both, one stroke for the two of them —

Brim got there first. Not between. *Under.* Launching up into the limb's path, wings wide, coal blazing like a struck flare, he caught the blow the way a bell catches a hammer.

Wrong sound. Soft.

It recoiled. Then it stayed, and curled onto him, enfolding, unhurried. It had his name.

"*Brim!*" Ava lunged for him — and Miren's arms locked around her from behind, hauling her back, as the pages folded over velvet and copper, as Brim was drawn up into the nest of the thing, wings pinned, coal guttering —

And here was what the name bought. What her gift was worth, at the end, in the only currency this place honored.

He did not smooth away. Nothing about him blurred. The Forgotten woman on the midway had gone soft at the edges and forgotten to mind. Brim went into the dark entirely himself — eyes clear, eyes kind, eyes on Ava the whole way.

"She'd have liked how you draw me," he said, calm as bedtime, eyes on Ava.

The pages folded to his shoulders. And Ava's face broke, because that was an answer, and it was the wrong time for it, and he gave it to her anyway. It was his gift.

"It's been my honor."

The pages closed to his chin. His coal-glow bled through the layers, dimming, a lantern lowered into deep water.

"Now find a way to survive," he said, muffled, last.

And the coal went out. Dark, in the layered pages. Dark, in the deep of the nest. Dark.

The Hunter walked on toward the tent with both of its parcels — one screaming and thirteen, one silent and finished. And the midway lights came back up behind it, string by string by string, cheerful as ever, lighting an empty crossing where a family used to be standing.

Miren held Ava and did not let go. Ava was not screaming. That was the worst part. She was making no sound at all — the scream already spent, hours ago, into a dark that keeps things.

Carter stood where his brother had been, and opened one hand. Leo's feather — torn loose in the fight, cord snapped, still warm. Still glowing. Faint, but stubborn.

Dawn's gold climbed another finger's width up the sky.

♦

The three of them wedged back into the tin dark. Nobody had said anything yet. The gold line through the rust-hole was higher than it had ever been, and it was moving. Ava sat with Brim's ward-stitches — the snapped ends wound in her fingers. She hadn't put them down. She wasn't going to. Miren's jaw worked at something it couldn't chew.

Carter hunched over the feather in his hands and broke the silence from the bottom of his chest.

"I saw her go."

Ava's head came up slow.

"The night of the crash. I got up for water. She was at the side table with the lockbox open — and she took the ticket, and she put it in her coat. And I watched

her do it." A beat. "Dad was already out front with the engine running. He drove her."

"Carter —"

"She saw me on the stairs. She put one finger up — like, *shh.* Like it was a birthday thing. A surprise."

"How old were you?" Miren said, quiet, from the rust-hole.

"Sixteen. She'd promised pancakes in the morning. So I went back to bed."

Ava didn't move. Two years' worth, finally out loud. The thing under *she left us.* The thing the funhouse book had known.

"That's the line I read in my book," Carter said. "It knew before I ever told anybody." Silence in the tin. And then, wrecked, plain: "I'm not the one who holds it together, Ava. I'm the one who watched."

A long moment. Then Ava moved — not to hold him. To sit beside him, shoulder against his shoulder, Brim's thread still wound in her fist.

"You were sixteen. She put her finger to her lips. That's not on you."

"Ava —"

"And I can't carry your guilt too. So I won't." And here it was, out loud, after two years. "I'm going to ask you for something instead."

"Anything."

"Help me get our brother back." A beat. "Not *for* me. *With* me."

Carter looked at her — at the shield asking, for the first time in two years, to be a sister with a plan instead of a wall. And nodded. "With you."

Miren turned from the rust-hole and leveled them both. "Then somebody better have one. In an hour, that tent finishes your brother. And nobody — *nobody* — walks in through that flap and back out —"

Tap. Tap. Tap. Polite. On the culvert tin.

Everyone froze. Miren's knife was out —

Stooping into the culvert mouth came a Forgotten. Smudged pencil-lines. Half a face. Wearing a hat. He tipped it. Polite as Sunday. And at the culvert's lip, faint in the gold, hung thread-wards — Miren's knots. He had followed the only things in the whole Book that were tied in love.

♦

Minutes earlier, in the antechamber of the big top —

Ink-rope, in loops of cursive, bound Leo to a bench of stacked programs. Every rope was a sentence — about him, and tightening as it revised. Even the walls in here breathed, and beyond the canvas was a vast slow heartbeat: the Heart, warming up for dawn. Guarding him, motionless by the flap, stood a Forgotten in a hat.

Leo studied his guard the way he studied everything — scraped, tear-streaked, wrung out. And did what Leo did. He made conversation.

"You tipped your hat to us. Nobody does that by accident. That's a thing you kept."

Nothing. Not a turn of the half-face.

"Name?" said the Book, from everywhere, patient.

"Do you remember yours?" Leo asked the guard, ignoring it.

The Forgotten's mouth moved. Nothing came out — the same nothing as the woman on the midway. That name was spent, gone, filed.

"Name," said the Book.

Leo nodded slowly. Thought. Thirteen years old, tied up in a story that ate names. And he reached for the one rule that ran the other direction.

"A friend taught me the rule tonight. So I'm giving you one. Not taking. *Giving*." He looked the Forgotten up and down — the hat, the Sunday politeness, the patience. And decided. "Walter. You look like a Walter."

The name landed.

And through the smudged half-face, the edges steadied. Lines that had been drifting settled and held. The Forgotten — Walter — looked down at his own hands like a man finding his keys where he'd left them. And when he looked up, there was a face there. Not whole. But there.

"...Walter," he said. Rusty. His first word in years.

And far below the antechamber floor, down in the deep of the tent, small and dry and unmistakable, a pen wrote. Six letters' worth.

Leo heard it. He'd known he would. He had watched that exact sound cost Brim everything. And he had named the man anyway. Walter heard it too, and tipped his hat toward the sound, unbothered. Findable was a small price for having a face.

"The woman on the midway," Leo said, thinking out loud, to the first person all night who only listened. "It got her whole name, and she just... went. She gave it up scared." He looked at the ink-ropes, at the sentences revising themselves around his wrists. "But Brim went in *whole.* Eyes open. It could carry him and it still couldn't *unwrite* him — because his name isn't in his own pocket anymore. Ava's holding it." A long beat. The ropes revised. The boy didn't. "It's the direction. Scared, it keeps you. Loved... you're held. It can't file what somebody else won't put down."

Walter pressed the hat to where a heart had been. Listening was also a thing he'd kept.

"Walter." Leo leaned close, fast, low. "I need you to carry one message for me. Can you do that?"

Walter tipped his hat.

♦

Now. The culvert. The knife lowered. Walter stooped in the tin mouth, holding his hat to his chest like someone at a door with news. And out of him, in a voice not used in years, came one message, recited exactly.

"'Come to the tent. Come together.'"

Silence in the culvert.

"That's not a plan," Miren said. "That's a boy walking into the Heart on *purpose* —"

"No." Ava, slow, working it. "It's Leo." She looked up at Carter, and something was catching light behind her eyes. "He's not asking us to rescue him."

Carter looked at the feather in his hand. Glowing. Stubborn. Pointing, all night, exactly the way nobody had wanted to go.

"He's asking us to trust him."

He closed his fist around the cord and stood a little straighter.

A beat. Then Miren exhaled — the long, furious exhale of a survivor about to do the least survivable thing she had ever heard of.

"Six years. Six years I don't answer to *anything*, and a thirteen-year-old mails me an invitation." She stood, cinching her knife-strap. "Boneyard's done. We go in the front."

And beyond the fence, down the bright empty midway, the big top waited with its flaps wide open. Like it had heard. Like it was holding the door.

♦

The last hundred feet of open ground. And every Forgotten on the midway was kneeling — foreheads to the boards, hats in hands, arranged in one long, patient line. A line that pointed at the tent.

She had already gone in. The world was bowing at her wake.

They walked the aisle she left.

♦

They came through the flaps four abreast — Carter, Ava, Miren, and Walter holding the canvas like an usher — into the last tent.

And inside was not a tent. Inside was the Heart.

A center ring of raked white sand that was not sand — it was page, blank, waiting, lit from nowhere. Above it, vast as weather, hung the underside of the Book itself: a ceiling of bound spines and turning leaves, breathing its slow dawn-ready breath. And filling the stands on every side sat the Forgotten. Hundreds of them. Politely seated. An audience that had waited a very long time for an ending. Hovering over the ring, in a patient row, were three pages, half-written, revising themselves in real time.

The ink-rope lay pooled like shed handcuffs at the feet of Leo — under the pages, small and scraped, and standing.

"*Leo* —" Ava.

He turned and found them, and he was too tired to look surprised. He'd known they would come. That had been the plan.

And stepping out from beside the pedestal, hat in his hands, in the flesh at last, came Gideon Marr.

"Welcome back. All three." He looked them over. "You have your mother's punctuality."

Carter crossed the sand — Miren's knife half-drawn behind him — two years and one whole carnival of fury arriving chest to chest with the old man.

"You knew her. You knew what this place was, and you sold him a *ticket.*"

"Yes."

It stopped Carter cold, the plainness of it.

"I could dress it up — I'm good at that, it's the job. But it's dawn, and I'm tired."

"Then say it plain."

"I lost mine in here." Gideon looked up at the breathing Book. "Both of them. And every year since, I've fed it other people's children, trying to buy mine back."

"Plainer."

"I knew. I chose. Every time." Plainer than he'd said anything all night. No apology in it — a man laying his ledger face-up in front of the children he owed.

"And what did it ever give you back, gatekeeper?" Miren said from the ring's edge, knife loose.

Gideon looked at her — the girl from the seams, six years feral — and let something move behind his eyes that he did not permit to reach his face.

"Receipts."

The Book exhaled.

Every page overhead turned at once. In the stands, the Forgotten rose, and went silent. And folding out of the dark between the spines, down into the ring, came the Executioner.

"Dawn," she said. One word, and the tent believed her. Along the canvas walls, gold light bled through the weave. Outside, somewhere real, a sun was clearing the trees. "Three pages. One debt. The terms have not changed." To the siblings, patient: "One remains and is finished. Two walk free. The Book is not cruel. It is only owed." And then, patient as a mercy: "The terms were revised once tonight. The two who walk may walk unburdened, with no memory that a third ever was."

"We keep him." Carter, before it finished. And his voice did not shake. "Even the missing him."

Somewhere behind the stitched armor, something filed that answer.

She raised the quill-knife and let the whole tent see it.

"Every story needs an ending."

And the three pages descended.

♦

EPISODE SIX

She Came Back

♦

They came down like verdicts, one to each sibling, hovering at heart height. And the pages began to write.

Carter's page raced ink, building him a pedestal in prose. Across the top, in tall proud letters: THE MAN WHO HELD IT TOGETHER. His feet slid toward the ring's center without his permission, sand rising around his boots like setting stone, and words crawled up his sleeves — SAY THE WORD AND THEY ARE SAFE.

Ava's page ignited the half-carved brand on her arm, gold and eager, finishing its sentence at last — S I L E N T G U A R D — and up from her wrist, gray and smooth and painless, came stone.

Leo's page was barely writing at all. Just one word, repeated, patient, filling every line. NAME. NAME. NAME. And at his edges — his fingers, the hem of him — a soft smudging. The world losing interest in keeping him whole.

"Choose," the Executioner said, even, almost kind. "Or dawn chooses."

Carter stood calf-deep in stone-sand, the words winding up his arms. And here it was — the offer he had almost signed at the mirror, delivered to his body now instead of his hand. Say the word. Decide for them. Die deciding. He looked at his brother, smudging at the edges. Thirteen.

And Carter London did the hardest thing the night had asked of anyone.

He knelt.

Sand cracked off him as he forced himself down to Leo's eye height, the hero's words shattering off his sleeves like dried mud.

"Leo. It's your call." Clear, so the whole tent heard it. "Whatever you're doing — we're with you. Tell us what you need."

Carter's page stuttered overhead, its tall proud title hanging unfinished, a hero mid-sentence with nobody left to save. Command starved it.

Ava turned to her brothers — stone at her elbow now, climbing — and did the thing two years had made almost impossible.

"Carter. Hold my hand." A beat, through her teeth. "I can't do this part alone."

His hand closed on hers. And the stone stopped. Confused. Held, she stopped fitting the sentence, her page hanging mid-word, the brand's gold guttering.

Jaw set, Ava raised her free hand to the air over the ring, to the space where three pages hovered, and touched the world like a page.

"Mom's voice. The real one. The last clear piece of it." She was choosing first. "Take it."

And she drew.

One line. One long unbroken breakpoint, through the air, through the binding-threads of all three pages at once — the same line she'd cut through the chains, through the beast of her own guilt, all night, in miniature, practicing without knowing for *this.* A curl of gold smoke lifted off the line. And somewhere in her a kitchen went quiet. A lullaby lost its melody and kept its words. She staggered. Carter held her up. And her face was the face of someone paying full price and not looking away from the register.

The three pages shuddered. Their binding-threads frayed. Almost. Almost —

"It is not enough," the Executioner said.

She was right. The threads held, by one strand each. Because a page is anchored by its name, and their names were still the Book's to demand.

"Finish, little page." To Leo — and the whole tent leaned. "Say your name."

Silence. Standing in the ring, smudged at the edges, Leo had one word filling the air over his head. NAME. NAME. NAME. He looked at the Executioner, at the breathing Book, at the stands of the waiting dead. And took his time.

Then he turned his back on all of it. To Carter. To Ava. The tent's whole attention on his shoulder blades.

"A name given in fear gets kept." Steady. A beat. "A name given in love gets *held.*"

He took his brother's hand, then his sister's. Three of them, one knot, center ring.

"My name is Leo London." And then, only to them: "I'm not saying it. I'm *giving* it. Keep it for me."

The air around them cracked like a spine.

"Carter London. Yours."

"Ava London. Yours."

At the ring's edge, though, stood Miren — watching three children hand each other their names, the one thing nobody had been left to do for her. And something in her face came unlocked the rest of the way.

Three names, spoken aloud in the Heart of the Book. And the ink came for them — all of it, every hungry line in the tent lunging for the sound —

And slid off.

Nothing to grip. No fear to hook into. Entrusted, the names had landed in held hands.

The last three binding-threads snapped. The pages tore free — blank of them, unwritten — three sheets of nothing spiraling down into the ring like leaves.

And the Book screamed. Every spine overhead flexed, the stands groaned, the Forgotten swayed like wheat. A sound like a library losing its argument with gravity.

♦

Dawn-gold flooded the canvas seams. At its edges the tent began to unravel, the chapter closing with nothing left to close on.

"The debt's still *open* —" Miren shouted over it. "It'll take the whole chapter down with it — everybody *out* —"

"No."

The Executioner crossed the ring on that one word, and the unraveling itself paused to listen. Unhurried, quill-knife rising, three children in her path and one strand of law left to cut them with.

"The story collapses, or the debt is paid. *Choose* is not among the options. Owed: one ending —"

"Yes."

Everyone turned. Even her.

Gideon stood at the pedestal, his hat set down at last on the rail, rolling up one sleeve like a man late for honest work. And the sleeve told the night's last secret. Ink. Old ink, risen past the elbow, veined into him like a tide that had been coming in for years — the thing he'd been hiding under showman's cuffs all night.

"It is owed. And it was never theirs." To the Executioner — to something in the Executioner. "It was mine before any of them. I sold the tickets."

He set his hand flat on the pedestal and called it up like frost forming: his own ledger. Every ticket he had ever torn, entry after entry, a column six years deep. And at the bottom, a signature line, waiting the way it had waited for six years.

"Gideon — what are you —" Carter started.

The Executioner moved — quill-knife up, fast for the first time all night, an enforcer streaking to stop a substitution the Book had never ordered —

And Miren stepped into her path.

Into the ring. Between the knife and the old man. The pocket watch up in her fist, open, faceup. A man. A girl. A woman. Smiling.

"Dad."

Not a plea. A name, given in love. The first one anyone had given the old man in six years.

The mask tilted. And from under the stitched armor, soft, unasked, unstoppable: *tick*.

The quill-knife stopped mid-stroke. And then it lowered. Her arm, lowering it. Her choice. Nobody in the ring was making her. One beat, mid-ring. It was a mother hearing her daughter's voice.

One beat was enough.

Gideon looked at his daughter now, not at the ledger, and ran the arithmetic one last time. Watching it land was terrible: the daughter he had spent six years buying back had been free the whole night. A stranger had paid. And the girl had stayed anyway.

He signed. With the good arm. GIDEON MARR — each letter surfacing in ink that came from him, up through his hand, the color leaving his knuckles, his wrist, climbing. And the ink that climbed him now was not the ink that had already been there. This was a man spending.

"Closing a sale," he said, not looking up — almost cheerful, entirely broken. And then, quieter, to nobody, the only true thing he'd said in twenty years: "...I'll take the ending."

The Book accepted.

And up in the stands, among the standing Forgotten, half-lit in the dawn-gold, stood a girl with a backpack, a library book still under one arm. Leo saw her.

Ink climbed him — elbow, then shoulder, taking its time. Fighting nothing, Gideon stood straighter as it rose, a man fitting into a coat he'd ordered long ago, while overhead the great spines folded down around the pedestal, gentle as a hand cupping a moth.

"Your mother out-wrote it once," he said to the siblings, last and quick, salesman to the end. "Blood tells." And to Miren, only Miren: "Mind the seams, Miren. They mind you back." Her name. He had never once used it. And then, with the last of his voice, in the grammar the tent had just taught him: "Gideon Marr." Pressing it to her like a ticket. "Keep it for me."

Miren took it. The way you take a thing there's no box for. A nod, fierce and final.

And the Book took him whole. Not filed. Installed — into the page, into the deep machinery of the place. A keeper where a debt used to be. His name never touched the Book. It rode out in his daughter's keeping. Held, like Brim.

The unraveling slowed — held, the way a held breath is held. And the ledger-lines over the ring rewrote themselves: GATEKEEPER: RECEIVED. OWED: ONE ENDING.

Silence in the ruin. Gideon was gone, and the bill was still on the table.

"Somebody still has to end her story," Miren said, reading it, hollow.

Above the pedestal, then, the Book turned one more page. Sara's contract. The printed law. The torn line where a name used to be — and above it, small and furious, the margin note. *Not my children. — S.*

Carter — the watcher, the one who counts — stepped up first, for once in his life. He took the ticket stub from his chest pocket. Her rusted ink. The sentence that leaves.

"I watched her go that night. I've called it my fault for two years and never once said the other half out loud." He laid the stub on the contract, her handwriting faceup, torn edge to torn edge. "She wasn't leaving us. Dad had the engine running. She was going back — to pay it herself, so it never touched us." Steady, witness-plain. "I'm the one who watched. So take it from the one who saw: that's how her story starts."

Ava took Leo's hand. Then Carter's. The knot, one more time — around the contract now, around her.

"Together," she said.

Leo looked at the tear. At his mother's handwriting. He had been finishing this sentence in his head for two years.

"You've been waiting on her ending," he said — to the Book, to the whole breathing acre of it. "Holding this whole chapter open for it. And your own page

already says how it goes: *those who escape must one day return.*" And here was the cost, and he paid it. "She got out. She saved somebody's kid on her way. And when you sent for her — she came. Four minutes from your gate." Quiet, steady, thirteen. "She came back. That's the ending. Write it."

One long, vast rustle. A library making up its mind.

And a page, somewhere overhead, took it down: SHE CAME BACK.

The ledger-lines rewrote one last time, and went still. OWED: — PAID.

And the unraveling stopped.

♦

Burning clean through the tent wall, where Ava's breakpoint had cut the air, opened a seam of light, tall as a door. And through it: trees. Leaf-litter. A morning the real world was having anyway.

"*Go!*" Miren shouted.

Running — Carter hauling Ava, Ava gripping Leo, Walter ahead of them holding the burning seam's edge like a doorman born to it. And one last time, out of the Hunter's nest, from the dark of the collapsing stands, came a voice.

"Leo. Baby. Don't go." Sara's voice. One final cast.

Leo stopped at the seam, one foot in morning. He didn't turn around.

"You're not her." Quiet, certain, thirteen. "She'd want us to go."

Nothing answered. The collapsing chapter inhaled the Hunter home — pages and nest and every stolen voice — and slid shut like a drawer on the whole idea of it.

Ava — one foot in the morning, his name still hers to hold — called into the dark, once. "*Brim!*"

Deep in the closing pages, far down, faint: a single gold pulse. A coal answering to its name. She saw it. She'd keep it.

They looked back at the seam's edge, because Miren wasn't crossing. She'd planted her feet in the ring's ruin, thread wound round her fist — a girl on the inside of the door, choosing it.

"Miren — come *on* —" Ava.

"Nineteen people in my seams. A camp. A wall of things worth guarding."

And standing where the pedestal had been — across the unraveling ring, canvas coming down around her like weather — was the Executioner. Her mask, hairline-fine, where the tick lived —

Cracked.

One second. One second of a human face behind the parchment. Wet, terrified, awake. Seen by nobody in this world except the girl with the watch.

"Mom." Small — thirteen again, just for one word.

The mask sealed. The Executioner turned away, into the settling dark, unhurried as ever. But her gloved hand, at her side, was open. Not fisted. Open.

Miren watched the dark her mother had gone into. "Hers got taken," she said, half to herself. "There's nothing left of it to hold." Then she backed away

toward the deep seams, and when she spoke again she was steadier than she'd been all night. "This is my page. I'm not finished with it."

"We'll come back," Leo said.

"I know." And there, finally, a real smile, scar tissue and all. "It's the family rule."

The seam flared — starting to close. Too fast. *Too fast* —

Walter planted himself in the burning edge and held it. The way Brim had held the gap.

"Walter — come on!" Carter.

Walter looked back at them. Tipping his hat was the whole speech. And the closing chapter took him the way it had taken Brim — found, held, entirely himself, a man with a face going wherever kept things go.

The seam's lip bucked, snapping shut —

And one thread moved the other way.

Against the unraveling. Against the current of everything. One single thread whipped across the seam's burning lip and held it, one breath's worth, tied off in a knot they had seen once before. Older. Finer. A knot like a signature. Ava saw it. Of course she saw it.

Leo, one foot in the morning, took one last look at the dark — the whole Book of it, her handwriting in there somewhere, finished now.

"Tell her we finished the sentence," he said, to the dark, to her page wherever it was.

They leapt.

And behind them, in the last inch of the closing world, the thread stitched one small torn scrap shut on its way down, quick and unthanked. And slipped away into the dark between the pages.

♦

Birdsong. Real birdsong, unrehearsed, a little off-key. Leaf-litter and low sun and cold clean air that didn't smell like paper at all.

Lying where the leap had dropped them, in a rough three-pointed star, were the Londons.

Carter's eyes opened first. He scrambled up on old instinct and counted — one, two — and stopped himself. Made himself watch them wake on their own instead. Ava. Then Leo. Dirt-streaked, ink-smudged, blinking up at a blue and ordinary sky.

"We're out," Ava said, hoarse.

Beyond the treeline, where a carnival had stood, was a trampled ring of grass. Tent-shaped absences. Tire ruts already filling with dew. One strand of dead bulbs left behind in the weeds, and nothing else at all.

Leo sat up. And went still. Because lying in the leaves beside him — closed, plain, no bigger than a hymnal — was the Book. Quiet. Inert. Half-covered in leaf-litter, patient as ever.

Nobody touched it. Nobody spoke for a while.

"River," Ava said. "There's a river two miles from here. It can learn to swim."

"It kept Miren. And Walter. And —" Leo couldn't say Brim yet — his voice went around it. "— it's not just *it* in there."

"And if we leave it here," Carter said, "somebody's kid finds it by Friday."

Ava glared at the Book. At Carter. Back at the Book. "I hate that you're right," she said, small and bitter.

"We take it. We watch it." Leo. A beat. "And we decide if it opens again. Not it."

A hush. Wind moving the trees like pages nobody was afraid of. Carter knelt and gathered the Book up with both hands, carefully, the way you'd lift something sleeping, and tucked it under one arm.

"On our terms."

He pulled his brother and sister up off the ground, one hand each, and turned them toward the low sun and the road. Three kids walked out of the woods, dwarfed by the trees. Together.

♦

Three weeks later.

A different kitchen — smaller, rented, alive. Sun through clean glass. Drawings on the fridge again, new ones. And at the stove, flipping something with unearned confidence, stood Leo. Smoke. A little. Nobody panicked.

"That one's Carter's."

"You're burning them," Carter said from the table, not getting up, a miracle in itself.

"I'm *caramelizing* them."

"He learned that word yesterday," Ava said, passing through, snagging juice. "He's been waiting."

Pancakes. Bad ones. The griddle-smell of a promise kept late, by the wrong cook, which is the only way some promises survive. Carter accepted a scorched pancake with the gravity of a man accepting a medal. Ate it. Didn't fix it. Didn't fix anything.

By the window, Ava settled with a new sketchbook, its first page already worked: Brim. Whole. Wings full, coal lit, mid-bow, courtly and ridiculous. Underneath, in her steadiest hand, four letters. And no dates.

She hummed as she shaded — an old lullaby. And the tune went missing halfway through the line. Just gone. A tooth-gap where the melody had been. Her pencil stopped. One breath.

Then, quietly, Leo picked it up from the stove. Not the tune. The words. Spoken off-hand, like passing the salt.

"'...names are thread. Pull too hard —'" He wasn't looking over.

"'— you disappear,'" Ava finished, steady.

She looked at him. He shrugged — the little-brother shrug, the one that means everything and admits nothing. She went back to her shading and kept the words. The feeling under them held her weight fine.

At the table, Carter slid something across the wood to Leo's place. The feather. Cord mended — re-knotted, clumsy, double-tied. Fixed by hand.

"Found it in my jacket," Carter said. "Figured you'd want it back."

Leo picked it up. Turned it once, his thumb finding the worn groove. Then he looped it over his neck, where it lived.

"Thanks."

That was the whole conversation. It was enough. It was the most enough anything had been in two years.

On the wall by the hallway hung the family photo from the old house — all of them at the fair, smiling like people who don't know yet. Hung, and straightened, and looked at. Leo passed it on his way out of the kitchen, and didn't stop to search it for answers. Just touched the frame once, *tap*, like a base runner touching home.

♦

A small room, honestly slept in. Homework half-done on the desk. The half-drawn picture pinned above it, still unfinished, still three figures and a scratched-out fourth, left exactly as it was. Some pages you keep without finishing.

Leo, in bed, reached for the lamp. And paused.

Across the room, on the closet shelf, wrapped in an old pillowcase and tied with Miren-grade knots, sat a book-shaped bundle. Quiet. Kept. Three weeks, and it hadn't so much as rustled. It had a keeper now.

Leo looked at it a long moment, the way you look at a locked door you own the key to. Then he turned off the light.

Darkness. The ordinary kind. A fridge humming somewhere, at peace. A car passing. A house holding a family that fit it.

And on the closet shelf, from one fold of the pillowcase, a single ink-mote rose, drifted, caught a thread of streetlight — and for half a second, no longer than a heartbeat, it glowed. Faint. Gold. A coal that refuses to quit. Then it settled, unhurried, the way a small courtly thing settles in for the night.

Silence.

Not gone. Held.

♦